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A YOUTH
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HISTORY AND
SOCIAL SCIENCE

Jazz and the American Dream

Talia Kriegel

The Kurdish quest for autonomy

Andy Zhang

Frederick Douglass's legacy

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Cover Image: Black Lives Matter protest in Washington, D.C., June 1, 2020—as discussed in Coby Mulliken's article on the history of policing. Photo by Kosu Kunii on Unsplash.

EDITOR'S NOTE

Dear Readers,

Welcome to the inaugural issue of Prism, a student-run journal of history and social science founded by and for high school students. We decided to establish Prism to fill what we see as a void in the high school publishing space: that of academic works on history and the social sciences. At Milton Academy, we saw first hand how talented young writers can be, and how innovative and bold their arguments often are; that such high quality writing often goes unrecognized, we found regrettable. Through Prism, we hope to provide a channel for these writers to publish the work they are most proud of, disseminate innovative research and interpretation, and motivate the creation of high-quality work.

In this issue, you will find a wide range of historical arguments and analyses, with topics ranging from the authoritarian political movements of twentieth-century Louisiana to the political theories underpinning Kurdish nationalism. While we did not choose to adopt a theme for this issue, we believe that each and every one of the articles contained herein reflects Prism's editorial commitment to publicize work that is not only accurate and enlightening, but also deeply *relevant*. In that vein, we commit to continue publishing works which shed light upon the difficult social issues of the present by looking to the past. Above all, we hope for Prism to be accessible; if you have any work you would like considered for publication or would like to be involved in this nascent stage of our journal's development, please do not hesitate to reach out.

Sincerely,

The Editors-in-Chief,

Coby Mulliken and Trew Strong

12/12/2021

PEACE OR PERSECUTION?

Race, Class, and Colonialism in the Development of American Policing, 1840-1870

COBY MULLIKEN

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IN THE UNITED STATES TODAY, few institutions are more controversial than the police. While positions on the topic vary greatly, with some figures calling for total abolition and others declaring their unconditional support, the centrality of the topic to American political discourse is undeniable.¹ To illustrate this fact, one need look no further than the protests against police brutality that engulfed the nation following the murder of George Floyd by the Minneapolis Police Department. Those protests garnered the attendance of roughly 20 million Americans, likely making them the most widely attended protests in American history.² It would be a mistake, however, to assume that this conflict between police and their opponents is entirely unique within American history or that police became involved in repression only recently. Rather, law enforcement forces have participated in social conflict for as long as they have existed, from the first night watches established by the European settlers to the mass surveillance and counter-intelligence of the Cold War FBI.

Yet today, the narrative that police developed solely in order to ensure the safety of the average citizen persists, manifesting itself everywhere from encyclopedias to public

¹ Examples of these positions include Tom Cotton, "Send In the Troops," editorial, *New York Times*, June 3, 2020, accessed April 28, 2021, <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/06/03/opinion/tom-cotton-protests-military.html>, and Mariame Kaba, "Yes, We Mean Literally Abolish the Police," editorial, *New York Times*, June 12, 2020, <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/06/12/opinion/sunday/floyd-abolish-defund-police.html>.

² For an upper bound estimate, see *KFF Health Tracking Poll*, 11, June 2020, <https://files.kff.org/attachment/Topline-KFF-Health-Tracking-Poll-June-2020.pdf>; for a lower bound see Kim Parker, Juliana Horowitz, and Monica Anderson, *Amid Protests, Majorities Across Racial and Ethnic Groups Express Support for the Black Lives Matter Movement*, 16, June 12, 2020, https://www.pewresearch.org/social-trends/wp-content/uploads/sites/3/2020/06/PSDT_06.12.20_protest-report-TOPLINE.pdf.

discourse.³ Contrary to this belief, however, police forces in the United States arose less out of a need to prevent violent crime and more out of a desire to preserve racial, colonial, and class power structures. This development can be seen best in three disparate regions of nineteenth-century America: in the American South, where the racial hierarchies of the antebellum period were preserved by the emergence of organized law enforcement, in Los Angeles, where early police forces protected colonial hegemony, and in Chicago, where the nascent Chicago Police Department maintained the dominance of the local owning class. Even beyond these geographies, the establishment of organizations with a legal monopoly on force irrevocably shaped social and political hierarchies in ways that continue to reverberate today.

If one is to examine the development of police forces in conditions as varied as those that existed in the early United States, they must first answer the question, “What defines the police?” Beginning with sociologist Max Weber’s formulation of the state, which he defines as a “human community that claims the monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory,” one can broadly define police as the individuals to whom the government delegates that monopoly.⁴ The earliest forces fitting this definition in pre-independence America were not actually “police,” per se, but rather night watches, the first of which emerged in Boston in 1636.⁵ The night watch required individual citizens to volunteer their time to watch the streets and prevent lawlessness or crime (however it might locally have been defined).⁶ While in theory the system was well-designed, in practice it was anything but; watchmen frequently drank on job, or otherwise paid others to do the service for them.⁷ As one Raleigh resident complained in 1800, “Last Saturday night the warehouse... was broken open... yet the citizens of Petersburg are taxed to the amount of 1800 dollars... for the support of a night watch!”⁸ The other law enforcement institution present for much of American history is the sheriff’s office, and by extension,

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³ Antoinette W. Satterfield, “Police, History of,” in *The Social History of Crime and Punishment in America: An Encyclopedia*, ed. Wilbur R. Miller (SAGE Publications, 2012), <http://doi.org/10.4135/9781452218427.n536>.

⁴ Max Weber, “Politics as a Vocation,” in *From Max Weber: Essays in Sociology*, ed. C. Wright Mills (New York: Oxford University Press, 1946); Lawrence W. Sherman, “Perspectives on Police and Violence,” *The Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 452 (November 1980), <https://www.jstor.org/stable/1042755>; Jean-Paul Brodeur, “Police Et Coercition,” *Revue Française De Sociologie* 35, no. 3 (1994): 457, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3322215>.

⁵ Gary Potter, “The History of Policing in the United States,” Eastern Kentucky University, <https://plsonline.eku.edu/sites/plsonline.eku.edu/files/the-history-of-policing-in-us.pdf>.

⁶ Potter, “The History of Policing.”

⁷ Potter, “The History of Policing.”

⁸ “Raleigh, Tuesday, Aug. 26, 1800,” *Raleigh Register*, August 26, 1800, <https://link.gale.com/apps/doc/GT3012643035/NCNP>.

posse comitatus. Translating to “power of the county,” the posse comitatus had its roots in medieval England, where local sheriffs would occasionally call upon the armed men of a county to defend against invasion or apprehend a felon.⁹ In America, their roles stayed much the same. The property-owning males of a county would elect a sheriff, who would then capture fleeing criminals either via posse comitatus or hired deputies.¹⁰ But as the United States’ population exploded and underwent myriad social changes, these systems could no longer bear all that was asked of them.

The role of early police and police-like forces in preserving racial hierarchy in the Southern United States cannot be understated. But to fully understand the importance of Southern policing, one must first understand the dynamics of the slave economy. From the seventeenth century onwards, enslaved people formed the backbone of the Southern economy, toiling on cotton plantations and attending to White slave masters.¹¹ But this expendable source of labor came with a downside for White Southerners: as the population of enslaved people began to outnumber the White population in some states, slave rebellions became more likely.¹² As one Southern historian framed it, “The slave population presented the problem of a police control that would... hold in check this irresponsible and often dangerous part of Southern society.”¹³ And while the oversight and punishment of slaves had long been the domain of the slave owner, these tasks were often too taxing for the individual master to conduct himself.¹⁴

Thus emerged the slave patrol. With its roots in both medieval English law enforcement and the plantation societies of the seventeenth and eighteenth century Caribbean, slave patrols were tasked with controlling nearly every aspect of slave life.¹⁵ Legally, their principal task was the enforcement of slave codes, legal codes that restricted, among other things, the marriage, movement, and testimony of slaves.¹⁶ Broadly speaking, the in-

⁹ David B. Kopel, “The Posse Comitatus And The Office Of Sheriff: Armed Citizens Summoned To The Aid Of Law Enforcement,” *Journal of Criminal Law and Criminology* 104, no. 4 (Fall 2015): 772, <https://scholarlycommons.law.northwestern.edu/jclc/vol104/iss4/3/>.

¹⁰ Kopel, “The Posse,” 784-787.

¹¹ Kenneth M. Stampp, *The Peculiar Institution: Slavery in the Ante-bellum South*, vintage books ed. (New York: Vintage Books, 1989), 34.

¹² Sally E. Hadden, *Slave Patrols: Law and Violence in Virginia and the Carolinas* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2003), 6.

¹³ Howell Meadoes Henry, “The Police Control of the Slave in South Carolina” (PhD diss., Vanderbilt University, 1914), 28.

¹⁴ Hadden, *Slave Patrols*, 7.

¹⁵ Hadden, *Slave Patrols*, 3, 11.

¹⁶ Rose E. Vaughn, “Black Codes,” *Negro History Bulletin* 10, no. 1 (October 1946): 17-18, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/44174624>.

stitution was quite popular among White Southerners, and for good reason. In the words of James Henry Hammond, the former governor of South Carolina, “Small guards in our cities, and occasional patrols in the country, insure us a repose and security known nowhere else.”¹⁷ The “small guards” to which he referred were, of course, slave patrols. But how exactly did these patrols ensure security?

The answer lay in their manifold strategies and tactics of repression, those which would greatly shape policing in the years to come. One of the most important strategies used to suppress Black dissent or revolt was the “pass system,” which required patrolmen to detain and punish any slave caught leaving their plantation without a pass from their slavemaster. When some slaveholders began granting slaves more general passes, The Daily Telegraph of Colombia, South Carolina, registered their outrage at the measure:

A ‘general pass’... is an outrage on the community, illegal in itself and will no longer be recognized. With a proper and specific pass a slave is always safe... It must be obvious to every one, that where they neither limit the bearer to time or place, gross abuses must necessarily arise under them.¹⁸

The outrage likely came from a fear that lackluster enforcement of slave codes could enable slaves to gather in larger groups, and, ultimately, render slave patrols useless. Slave patrols, however, were not alone in providing violent protection to white supremacy. Constables—essentially unpaid policemen—were responsible for many of the same tasks as patrolmen, such as apprehending runaway slaves, enforcing the pass system, and breaking up gatherings of Black people, both enslaved and free.¹⁹ Though de jure separate, in practice the line between these two groups often blurred, with constables even paying slave patrols to capture runaways for them.²⁰

The niche that these groups filled, that being the enforcement of racial supremacy, never truly disappeared. Though slave codes were annulled after the Civil War, “black codes” remained, and they too demanded an institution to enforce them.²¹ In most cases, these new institutions (now officially called “police”) were not new at all, but rather replicas of the patrols that had preceded them. Staffed by a motley crew of former patrolmen

¹⁷ Hadden, *Slave Patrols*, 6.

¹⁸ Henry, “The Police,” 30. Limited information on citation in original.

¹⁹ Hadden, *Slave Patrols*, 83.

²⁰ Hadden, *Slave Patrols*, 84.

²¹ Theodore Brantner Wilson, *The Black Codes of the South* (Tuscaloosa: University of Alabama Press, 1965), 65-66.

and ex-Confederate soldiers, the reconstituted police departments continued to subjugate Black people and protect the white supremacist order.²² Overall, the development of organized police forces out of an array of white supremacist institutions, ranging from constables' offices to slave patrols, illustrated the immense role of hierarchy in stimulating the monopolization of legalized force. But just as police played a great role in protecting the Southern white ascendancy, the Western United States too had hierarchies in dire need of violent protection.

In Los Angeles, the necessity of preserving colonial hierarchy over the Native inhabitants made inevitable the proliferation of policing and incarceration. But before either the American or Spanish empires could force such practices on the hotly contested frontier town, the Native residents of the area lived with a justice system of their own. In this system, restitution and punishment for crimes were carried out "not on behalf of the larger community or village, but for the individuals who were wronged."²³ Come the Spanish conquest in the late eighteenth century, this order was quickly displaced by a far more punitive one, in which Native practices, like slash-and-burn farming, were prohibited and forced labor prevailed.²⁴ The laws imposed by the Spanish led to a rapid increase of the prison population, driven largely by the incarceration of male Natives who refused to work for the settlers at what were essentially starvation wages.²⁵ Among the Spanish population, incarceration was less common, and social order was mostly enforced by the strong ties of both family and church.²⁶

Yet even as social hierarchy abounded and the United States assumed control, the area still lacked a formal police force. Despite the lack of law enforcement, the first act of the new American government was to hire a jailer to staff the county jail, at that time the only publicly-owned property in the whole city.²⁷ But amid rising social unrest, violence, and racism towards Natives, jailing alone was seen as insufficient in terms of securing order for Los Angeles's White society. Although a sheriff's office, officially "The Los Angeles

²² Connie Hassett-Walker, "How You Start is How You Finish? The Slave Patrol and Jim Crow Origins of Policing," *Human Rights Magazine*, January 12, 2021, https://www.americanbar.org/groups/crsj/publications/human_rights_magazine_home/civil-rights-reimagining-policing/how-you-start-is-how-you-finish/.

²³ Steven W. Hackel, *Children of Coyote, Missionaries of Saint Francis: Indian-Spanish Relations in Colonial California, 1769-1850* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2005), 321.

²⁴ Kelly Lytle Hernández, *City of Inmates: Conquest, Rebellion, and the Rise of Human Caging in Los Angeles, 1771-1965* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press., 2017), 55-56.

²⁵ Hernández, *City of Inmates*, 57.

²⁶ Robert M. Fogelson, *The Fragmented Metropolis: Los Angeles, 1850-1930* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1967), 26.

²⁷ Hernández, *City of Inmates*, 61-62.

Rangers,” had been established in 1852, the murder rate in the county continued to grow, reaching a whopping 370 homicides per 100 thousand people by the mid-1850s.²⁸

However, violence was not the only issue driving White citizens to call for greater policing. In fact, the mere experience of living amongst those they regarded as inferior played just as great a role, as can be seen in this 1859 editorial in the *Los Angeles Star*:

The employment of Indians by civil authorities—more especially of the city—has been, and is daily productive of evil and deserving of unqualified condemnation. The Indians thus selected and clothed with a brief and illegal authority, are in no respect in advance of the mass of their degraded race; and the constantly recurring scenes enacted in our streets, wherein these miserable creatures of both sexes are dragged to jail by a crowd of equally miserable and oftentimes, more intoxicated and beastly Indian officials, serve but to divest law of its majesty.²⁹

The article, authored by the foreman of a local jury, followed this claim with a call for a vast expansion of vagrancy laws, which essentially provided for the incarceration of Natives living but not working in the city—all in all, a ploy to further convert the Native population into an entirely dependent work force.³⁰ The foreman’s demands were soon granted and the City Council gradually increased the scope of the codes, with the explicit intent of “compelling [Indians] to obtain an honest livelihood or seek their old homes in the mountains.”³¹ Naturally, expanded vagrancy laws would require a larger police contingent to enforce them, and thus was born the Los Angeles Police Department. From its inception in 1869, the department was beholden to the city’s ruling class, arresting scores of Natives, who, in many cases, were “auctioned [as slaves] to private employers.”³² As for crime prevention, the new police force remained fairly ineffective due to a combination of mismanagement, politicization, and corruption.³³ Throughout each era in Los Angeles’s early

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²⁸ Eric H. Monkkenen, “Homicide in Los Angeles, 1827-2002,” *The Journal of Interdisciplinary History* 36, no. 2 (Autumn 2005): 172, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3656155>. One should note that due to the relatively small population of Los Angeles at the time, per capita homicide statistics were incredibly volatile.

²⁹ W.M. H. Peterson, “Presentment of the Grand Jury -- February Term, A.D. 1859,” *Los Angeles Star*, March 12, 1859, <http://digitallibrary.usc.edu/cdm/ref/collection/p15799coll68/id/411>.

³⁰ Ronald C. Woolsey, “Crime and Punishment: Los Angeles County, 1850-1856,” *Southern California Quarterly* 61, no. 1 (Spring 1979): 80, <https://doi.org/10.2307/41170812>.

³¹ Hernández, *City of Inmates*, 68.

³² Hernández, *City of Inmates*, 64.

³³ Paul M. De Falla, “Lantern in the Western Sky,” *The Historical Society of Southern California Quarterly* 42, no. 1 (March 1960): 79, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/41169431>.

history, this cycle was repeated; the colonizing population would feel threatened by an underclass, impose restrictions on the rights of that underclass, and finally expand their use of force in order to secure those restrictions. In summary, although widespread violence and disorder had significant influence, it was ultimately the preservation of White colonial hegemony that necessitated the creation of organized law enforcement in Los Angeles.

Looking beyond racial and ethnic hierarchies, structures of class hierarchy too played a great part in stimulating the creation of police forces. Though such hierarchies were present in every major American city of the time, the city of Chicago is particularly instructive in illuminating this development. Chicago, like many other cities in the 1840s, was riddled with crime and unrest. Brawls frequently erupted in rum shops, fights broke out on street corners, and a general atmosphere of violence prevailed.³⁴ This sense was underscored by a background of immense ethnic and class-based strife, primarily between the native-born Protestant elite and a fast-growing Catholic immigrant working class, who by 1844 made up over 30% of the city's inhabitants.³⁵ Although the immigrant population, staffing factories, warehouses, and meatpacking plants, fueled much of the city's industrial growth, wealthy Protestants had become deeply suspicious of the group's culture.³⁶ Their objections were both economic and moral; on one hand, they opposed the immigrants' demands for better wages and union representation, and on the other they scorned the drinking culture that many Germans and Irish regarded as pastime.³⁷

It was the issue of drinking that ultimately brought the ruling and working classes into open conflict, and in turn, prompted the growth of the Chicago Police Department.³⁸ The conflict began in 1855, with the election of Mayor Levi Boone, a nativist temperance advocate running on the American Party line. In his inaugural address, he proclaimed his opposition to Catholics, who he claimed were "bound under an oath of allegiance to the

³⁴ John Joseph Flinn and John Elbert Wilkie, *History of the Chicago Police: From the Settlement of the Community to the Present Time, under Authority of the Mayor and Superintendent of the Force* (Chicago: Under the auspices of the Police Book fund, 1887), 56.

³⁵ Flinn and Wilkie, *History of the Chicago*, 57.

³⁶ Robert A. Slayton, *Back of the Yards: The Making of a Local Democracy* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1988), 21.

³⁷ David Moberg, "Antiunionism," in *The Encyclopedia of Chicago*, by James R. Grossman, Ann Durkin Keating, and Janice L. Reiff (University of Chicago Press, 2004), <http://encyclopedia.chicagohistory.org/pages/55.html>; Sam Mitrani, *The Rise of the Chicago Police Department: Class and Conflict, 1850-1894*, Working class in American history (University of Illinois Press, 2013), 14, PDF.

³⁸ One should note that the cultural and economic dimensions of the conflict were ultimately inextricable, and that the push for control over immigrant drinking culture was deeply related to the issue of class.

temporal, as well as the spiritual supremacy of a foreign despot.”³⁹ Additionally, he pledged to crackdown on Sunday drinking, a popular activity among the city’s working class, since Sunday was traditionally their only day off.⁴⁰ Though keen on fulfilling his promise, Boone soon encountered a problem: the city lacked a force capable of enforcing his anti-immigrant temperance legislation. Undeterred by the situation, he proceeded to hire eighty native-born policemen, who were put under his direct control.⁴¹ He also vastly expanded the powers of other city officials, granting both himself and the aldermen police-like powers.⁴² Finally, on April 21, 1855, a crowd of German protestors gathered at the Cook County courthouse, demanding that taverns be allowed to open on Sundays. Boone responded by ordering his newly formed police department to disperse the crowd and continue to arrest the defiant tavern-owners. In a standoff that would later come to be known as the “Lager Beer Riot,” protestors and policemen clashed for much of the day, resulting in one death and roughly sixty arrests.⁴³

While Boone, with his ordinance ultimately abandoned and unenforced, was unsuccessful in exerting social control over the city’s immigrant poor, in the long run his police force would have much greater success. As in other major cities, like New York and London, riots and strikes came to be far more effective at spurring elites to action than individual crimes like murder or theft.⁴⁴ In Chicago, the Lager Beer Riot served the same purpose; only nine days after, the City Council passed a slate of modernizing reforms to the city’s police department, in what “amounted to the department’s real founding.”⁴⁵ Even after Boone’s legacy had been mostly forgotten, the department continued to serve the purpose he had originally set out for it: protecting the interests of the city’s owning class. For example, the privately-owned Illinois Central railroad company made frequent use of the department (as well as private contractors) in protecting against strikers or other provocateurs.⁴⁶ Later, in the aftermath of the Great Fire of 1871, the department used extensive force to protect the property of the city’s wealthy, killing six supposed “arsonists” in

³⁹ Ron Grossman, “Chicago’s Lager Beer Riot proved immigrants’ power,” *Chicago Tribune*, September 25, 2015, <https://www.chicagotribune.com/history/ct-know-nothing-party-lager-beer-riot-per-flashback-jm-20150925-story.html>.

⁴⁰ Mitrani, *The Rise*, 14.

⁴¹ Mitrani, *The Rise*, 15.

⁴² Mitrani, *The Rise*, 20.

⁴³ Grossman, “Chicago’s Lager.”

⁴⁴ Daniel Walker Howe, *What Hath God Wrought: The Transformation of America, 1815-1848* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2007), 432.

⁴⁵ Mitrani, *The Rise*, 24.

⁴⁶ Carlton J. Corliss, *Main Line of Mid-America: The Story of the Illinois Central* (New York: Creative Age Press, 1950), 59.

the following weeks, despite little evidence to suggest that any arson had occurred at all.⁴⁷ As these events show, the conservation of class hierarchy constituted the most important factor in the founding and expansion of the Chicago Police Department.

However, one must note that neither Chicago, nor Los Angeles, nor even the American South can fully encapsulate the hierarchical nature of policing in America. Rather, hierarchies of all dimensions were instrumental in bringing about the creation of police departments across the country, in some cases reflecting deeply localized phenomena, like the dominance of a powerful family or the suppression of an insurgent political group. And while the locales discussed so far are indeed rather artificially chosen, together they reveal a society marred by a fundamental contradiction, that those appointed to protect citizens from violence are also tasked with violently upholding systems of caste. Whether and how American society will ever sort out this contradiction is impossible to know, but one thing is certain: America's police forces were founded to oppress, and, *sans* reckoning or insurrection, will continue to do just that.

⁴⁷ Mitrani, *The Rise*, 76-77.

SAIGU

The Korean Struggle Behind the Los Angeles Riots of 1992

HENRY DALLMAN

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*"People calling me things, you know, Nip, Chink, Jap. You know, after a while, I would get mad and start cussing right back, and then I'd be like, look, man, you want to call me Gook? Guess what. You're a - I would say racial slurs. It was bad."*¹

— Carol Park, Korean cashier

THE INFAMOUS LOS ANGELES RIOTS of 1992 revealed a groundswell of injustice and anger over the systemic racism that African Americans have faced throughout American history. The riots also highlighted deep complexities around other tensions, not only between African Americans and Whites, but also between African Americans and Koreans, who found themselves at the heart of the outbreak. The riots transformed Korean American identity and their social relationship with African Americans, exposing the effects of ethnic economic competition and cultural miscommunications in Los Angeles.

On March 3, 1991, Rodney King, an African American man, was involved in a car chase with police in the city of Los Angeles. Once King was apprehended, four white officers from the LAPD assaulted King, repeatedly beating him with batons for almost 15 minutes. A video taken by bystander, George Holliday, showed the graphic footage of the attack. The tape circulated to news sources and was broadcast throughout the nation. King sustained skull fractures, broken bones and teeth, and permanent brain damage.² A

¹ Mandalit del Barco, "Gas Station Cashier Remembers 1992 Los Angeles Riots," *NPR*, April 28, 2017, <https://www.npr.org/2017/04/28/526005520/gas-station-cashier-remembers-1992-los-angeles-riots>.

² Anjuli Sastry and Karen Grigsby Bates, "When LA Erupted In Anger: A Look Back At The Rodney King Riots," *NPR*, April 26, 2017, accessed April 19, 2021, <https://www.npr.org/2017/04/26/524744989/when-la-erupted-in-anger-a-look-back-at-the-rodney-king-riots>.

year later, on April 29, 1992, the four Los Angeles police officers involved were acquitted. Fueled by decades of racism and economic inequality, fury over the acquittal emptied into the streets of Los Angeles, resulting in five days of rioting, looting, and burning. In the years leading up to the riots, tensions had already been accumulating in African American communities. Along with a staggeringly high unemployment rate of nearly 50 percent, rampant drug usage, crime, and mass incarceration swept through Black neighborhoods.³ By the end of the five days of riots, more than 50 people were killed, over 2,000 were injured, and nearly 6,000 alleged looters and arsonists were detained. In all, approximately \$1 billion worth of property damage was sustained, and over 1,000 buildings were damaged or destroyed.⁴

Amidst the intensity and chaos of the riots, Korean immigrants meanwhile found themselves in a crucible of turmoil as their businesses were looted. At the time of the riots, there were over 145,000 people that identified as Korean living in Los Angeles County most of whom agreed the verdict was unjust.⁵ However, many Koreans held perceived positions of economic dominance over African Americans, and Korean stores and businesses located in primarily Black neighborhoods were targeted by rioters.⁶ As the five days of chaos came to an end, LA Koreans suffered heavy financial consequences: 2,280 Korean American-owned stores were looted, burned, or damaged, causing approximately \$400 million in losses.⁷ In the words of Dr. Man Chul Cho, a therapist who worked with Korean store owners after the riots, “[Koreans] were sympathetic... Then they were destroyed.”⁸ This predicament, however, was not a random act of inexplicable violence. Rather, the complex nature of Koreans’ economic position, the cultural differences between Korean merchants and Black customers, and Korean ignorance and indifference towards African Americans’ continued racial struggle in the United States, were all integral components of Koreans’ role in the riots. These challenges spurred Korean development in the Los Angeles community.

³ Sastry and Bates, “When LA Erupted.”

⁴ Sastry and Bates, “When LA Erupted.”

⁵ Seth Mydans, “Koreans Rethink Life in Los Angeles,” *The New York Times*, June 21, 1992, accessed May 4, 2021, <https://www.nytimes.com/1992/06/21/us/koreans-rethink-life-in-los-angeles.html>.

⁶ Sastry and Bates, “When LA Erupted.”

⁷ Edward Taehan Chang, *Los Angeles Riots and Korean-African American Conflict* (서울대학교 미국학연구소, 2002), <https://s-space.snu.ac.kr/bitstream/10371/88557/1/10.%20Special%20Address%20%20Los%20Angeles%20Riots%20and%20Korean-African%20American%20Conflict.pdf>.

⁸ Sandy Banks. “The damage went deep.” *Los Angeles Times*, May 1, 2012. Accessed April 15, 2021. <https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-2012-may-01-la-me-riot-koreans-20120501-story.html>.

The economic niche Korean Americans made for themselves created tension and competition with Black-owned businesses and in L.A. A main source of this tension derived from Korean Americans as “Middleman Minorities” in Black neighborhoods. “Middleman Minorities” refers to minority entrepreneurs whose customers are typically members of marginalized racial or ethnic groups that are segregated from a dominant group.⁹ The Middleman Minority Theory, coined by Hubert Blalock in 1967, explored the reasoning behind the common economic position into which many minority groups found themselves. One of the prominent features of a Middleman Minority (here, Korean Americans) was their reaction to hostility from the dominant group (Whites), usually on the basis of cultural or racial distinctiveness. As members of the Middleman Minority, they were pushed out of desirable occupations, yet they managed to escape the lowest rungs of economic pressure by closing ranks. Maintaining solidarity within their communities allows members of the Middleman Minority to thrive where other groups do not.¹⁰ Racial discrimination in the US affected (and still affects) many ethnic groups. Koreans, though perhaps not being the target of explicit legislative racism at the time, still faced racial biases and stereotyping just as other people of color in America had for centuries. As such, they responded in the manner the theory described. In Los Angeles, Koreans collaboratively focused their economic growth through entrepreneurship. By 1990, there were 6,000 Korean-owned businesses supporting nearly half of the Korean population in Los Angeles.¹¹ Pooling the resources of their community, Korean businesspeople often developed a competitive business edge, using the bond of a tight-knit community to achieve economic advantages other business owners could not. In particular, the ability to minimize labor costs through reliance on family members and fellow Korean workers willing to contribute long hours for little pay, was extremely impactful as Koreans entered the realm of economic competition.¹²

Korean immigrant solidarity was a key factor in Koreans’ economic success during this time, but also deepened the conflicted nature of their relationship with African American businesspeople. Professor Edward Taehan Chang of UC Riverside surmised that “Ko-

⁹ Karen Manges Douglas and Rogelio Saenz, “Middleman Minorities,” in *International Encyclopedia of the Social Sciences*, 2nd ed., comp. Martin Guha (2008), accessed April 21, 2021, <https://www.shsu.edu/~kmd007/documents/WinFSHD2Userskmd007ArticlesMiddlemenMinorities.pdf>.

¹⁰ Edna Bonacich, “A Theory of Middleman Minorities,” *American Sociological Review* 38, no. 5 (October 1973), accessed May 4, 2021, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/pdf/2094409.pdf>.

¹¹ Mydans, “Koreans Rethink.”

¹² Douglas and Saenz, “Middleman Minorities.”

rea is one of the most homogeneous societies in the world claiming to have one language, one culture, and one ethnicity.”¹³ The Korean community in Los Angeles embodied these characteristics and diligently exposed their children to Korean culture. The establishment of Koreatown (residential self-segregation), language and cultural immersion schools like the Korean Institute of Southern California (est. 1972) and the Korean School Association of America (est. 1982), and the tendency of Los Angeles Koreans to maintain distinctive cultural traditions, such as language, ethnic food, and religion, all contributed to a “primordial tie” that provided a basis for trust within the Korean community.¹⁴

The emphasis on shared culture allowed for both distribution of economic resources and lessening of internal competition. The circulation of resources included capital, such as low interest loans, the use of partnerships, information and training, and, perhaps most importantly, jobs and opportunities.¹⁵ On top of this, Korean store owners often operated their businesses through their own labor with assistance from immediate family members and other Korean associates. Employees would work long hours for low (or no) wage and were loyal to the business owners.¹⁶ While this effective combination of community and collaborative economics led to Korean immigrant prosperity, it also laid the foundation for the tension between the Korean American and the African American communities.

Two major issues impacted Korean and African American relationships: Korean entrepreneurs did not hire African American workers and Koreans did not contribute profits to the Black community.¹⁷ Racial biases and a broader sense of competition underscored the economic tension between the competing businesses, as is common when members of one race act as merchants, profiting off of another group of people, while adding little to nothing to their community. Some African Americans, as a result, began to view Korean Americans as yet another race attempting to profit from and exploit the suffering of Black people.¹⁸ Unfortunately, the underlying racial economic competition was not the only impetus for conflict between African Americans and Korean Americans—tension between the two groups arose at the level of customer interaction as well, revealing deep cultural differences that exacerbated the conflicts.

¹³ Chang, *Los Angeles*, 5.

¹⁴ Bonacich, “A Theory.”

¹⁵ Bonacich, “A Theory.”

¹⁶ Chang, *Los Angeles*, 5.

¹⁷ Chang, *Los Angeles*, 4.

¹⁸ Chang, *Los Angeles*, 4.

As Korean businesses spread throughout Los Angeles, a clash of cultures emerged in the interactions between Korean store owners and African American customers. As stated by Larry Aubrey, a consultant with the Los Angeles County Human Relations Division, “Monocultural people doing business in a multicultural society [is] potentially problematic.”¹⁹ Aubrey found that complaints from both Black and Korean people primarily involved social interactions, in particular, the subjects of customer treatment and communication. Korean store owners were described as “hostile... and rude,” while Koreans raised similar complaints towards Black customers.²⁰ As a product of drastically different cultures, each group carried different expectations concerning proper attitudes and behaviors in business settings.

If these expectations were challenged on either side, conflict emerged. In particular, Prof. Chang outlined Koreans’ grievances as loudness, bad language, and shoplifting, when the behaviour valued by shop owners was respect, courtesy, and frequent apologies. On the other hand, African Americans frequently commented on Koreans’ negative attitudes, habit of ignoring or watching Black customers constantly suspiciously, and disrespectful interactions with money.²¹ Conflicts arose in two distinct interactions between Koreans and African Americans: the transaction of business, and the Korean response to Black customers’ perceived misdemeanor. Korean transactional expectations are rooted in Korean culture and are therefore well-known among Koreans. However, Korean response towards Western customs reveals the insularity of Koreans’ immigrant background and experience.

This insularity was a root cause behind social tensions between Korean store owners and African American customers. The strong communal bonds Koreans created with each other, through their shared struggle and backgrounds, amplified Korean Americans’ monocultural experience. Koreans’ mode of interpersonal communication became a trigger for misunderstandings between Koreans and African Americans.

Korean culture honors two terms to a high degree in social interactions: ‘respect’ and ‘education.’ These terms carry more complex meanings in 한글 (hangul, the Korean language) than they do in English. The way in which Korean store owners use the term ‘respect’ strongly corresponds to the Korean word 존경 (jongyeong)²², used to describe

¹⁹ Larry Aubrey, interview by Miae Kim, Korean American National Museum in Los Angeles, CA, December 6, 2004.

²⁰ Aubrey, interview.

²¹ Chang, *Los Angeles*, 6.

²² Benjamin Bailey, “Communicative Behavior and Conflict between African-American Customers and Korean Immigrant Retailers in Los Angeles,” *Discourse & Society* 11: 8, accessed May 7, 2021, <https://citeseerx.ist.psu.edu/viewdoc/download>

the respect paid to a superior in a hierarchical relationship.²³ In Korean culture, respect for elders is of deep importance and age hierarchy is embedded in most social and business frameworks. Koreans' saw a lack of 'respect' frequently in the context of a younger customer, whom they felt did not show the proper forms of 'respect' Koreans believed appropriate for business interactions.

In tandem with the 'respect' of customers, Koreans interpreted many common Western cultural practices as lacking 'education'. The translation of 'education' in Korean, 교육 (gyoyug)²⁴, implies not only academic learning but also the training in proper forms of social and personal conduct.²⁵ Based in a strong Confucist history, Korean culture values the propriety of social interaction, learning to suppress the "seven passions of joy, anger, sorrow, fear, love, hatred, and desire."²⁶ The more 'educated' someone is, the less emotion they will display in everyday interactions. Behavior that many Western cultures might believe to be signs of sociability, things like small talk and jokes, are considered a sign of poor 'education' or manners by Korean immigrants.²⁷

These traits were best exemplified by the differences in conversation between Korean store owners and customers of Korean background, compared to interactions with those of African American background. A Brown University study videotaped unscripted interactions between Korean American shop owners and customers of different racial backgrounds in Los Angeles during 1994-95. The following partial transcript is an example of Korean-Korean interactions, which describes a short, efficient, and transactional style of communication. Both the customer and cashier display little emotion throughout the interaction and do not use this meeting to strengthen any relationship to each other.

Cashier: Annyo~ng haseyo.
Hello [*Customer has just entered store*]

Korean Customer: Annyo~ng haseyo. Tambae!
Hello. Cigarettes!

[load?doi=10.1.1.201.7785&rep=rep1&type=pdf](https://doi.org/10.1.1.201.7785&rep=rep1&type=pdf). The romanization of the word 존경 is written as *chonkyong*. Different English spellings for the phonetic pronunciation of Korean words are common, but they carry the same meaning.

²³ Bailey, "Communicative Behavior," 8.

²⁴ Bailey, "Communicative Behavior," 8. The romanization of the word 교육 is written as *kyoyuk*.

²⁵ Bailey, "Communicative Behavior," 8.

²⁶ June-Ock Yum, "Korean Philosophy and Communication," in *Communication Theory: Eastern and Western Perspectives*, comp. D. Lawrence Kincaid (San Diego, CA: Academic Press., 1987), 74.

²⁷ Bailey, "Communicative Behavior," 8.

Cashier: Tambae tu[˘] ryo[˘]yo?

You would like cigarettes? [*Cashier reaches for cigarettes under counter*]

Cashier: Yo[˘]gi issu[˘] mnida.

Here you are [*Cashier takes customer's money and hands her cigarettes; customer turns to leave*]

Cashier: Annyo[˘] nghi kaseyo.

Good-bye.

Korean Customer: Nye.

Okay.²⁸

In total, the conversation comprises 13 words (in the English translation), with neither person saying more than 4 words in a row. In comparison, a recorded conversation with an African American customer contained 279 words spoken, with the African American customer speaking 257 words in total. An excerpt from this conversation reveals multiple attempts by the customer to engage in conversation, but the Korean store owner and cashier grow less and less involved.

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Customer: I had a total [injured] knee so my company is retiring my- old black ass at fifty-four... [*Customer smiles and gazes at owner*]

Owner: Mmh. [*Owner shakes his head laterally and gazes away from the customer*]

Customer: And they give me some money.

Cashier: Huh. [*Cashier bares his teeth briefly in a smile*]

Customer: So I'm spending my money at your store on liquor heh heh heh heh hah hah. [*Customer laughs animatedly, turning toward the owner who does not smile, but who continues lateral headshakes as he takes a few steps to the side*]²⁹

Because the inclusion of personal topics in a business transaction was considered

²⁸ Bailey, "Communicative Behavior," 9.

²⁹ Bailey, "Communicative Behavior," 12.

rude (an example of improper ‘education’), the Korean employees respond by distancing themselves from the conversation, likely creating further tension with customers.

The root of the clash between Koreans and Black people did not solely originate from the differences in culture and social customs, but also from Korean identity as immigrants in the United States. Korean immigrants’ interpretation of the “American Dream” and Koreans’ ignorance of African American suffering, underpinned Korean behaviour towards Black customers. As voluntary immigrants, Koreans had a drastically different view of America compared to that of African Americans. The Immigrant Theory suggested that immigrants from Asian and Latin American origin would emulate traits of successfully assimilated European migrants, who placed emphasis on economic upward mobility through hard work, education, and a willingness to work long hours.³⁰ Even when encountering the obstacle of racism, Koreans nevertheless held fast to the ideals that hard work and academic education would achieve the “American Dream.”³¹

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As they were unacquainted with the suffering of African Americans (ie. slavery, segregation, systemic oppression, etc.), Koreans embraced the notion of the “land of opportunities,” showing little understanding towards the African American plight, and incorrectly surmising that African Americans had no one but themselves to blame for their problems.³² Because the value of social customs was so ingrained in Korean culture, the act of ignoring a customer who lacked social propriety was seen as an appropriate response. As one Korean merchant declared, “How can I smile at the customer who uses bad language and shows no respect for me?”³³ However, this type of Korean response struck the core of many systemic problems faced by African Americans, who have been oppressed, disregarded, and belittled for generations. Feeling ignored is a direct violation of one’s humanity, and, in the words of a Black customer at a Korean store, “[the store owners] wouldn’t look at you at all. They wouldn’t acknowledge you in any way. Nothing. You were nobody... They’d look over you or around you.”³⁴ Though the Korean response might have carried a different intention, these Korean cultural tendencies were understandably taken as insults to Black customers, exacerbating intolerance and prejudice on both sides.

The friction between Korean Americans and African Americans, grounded in eco-

³⁰ Chang, *Los Angeles*, 8.

³¹ Chang, *Los Angeles*, 8.

³² Chang, *Los Angeles*, 8.

³³ Chang, *Los Angeles*, 7.

³⁴ Chang, *Los Angeles*, 7.

conomic competition and cultural differences, was evident to many in Los Angeles. Carol Park, the Korean American daughter of a gas station owner, poignantly described the tension between Korean and African Americans. She recounted that “People would say, you know, damn Koreans. Get out of the hood. What are you doing here overcharging me for a can of soda? It was like a stick of dynamite waiting to explode.”³⁵ Ultimately, the tension between Koreans and African Americans did explode. However, it was not only the riots that marked the climax of the conflict, but a tragic event more than a year earlier. On March 16, 1991, only two weeks after the beating of Rodney King, Soon Ja Du, a Korean store owner, shot and killed a 15-year old African American girl, Latasha Harlins. Du accused the girl of stealing a bottle of orange juice and an altercation ensued. When Latasha placed the juice on the counter and began to exit the store, Du shot her in the head.³⁶ Not only was this event clear evidence of dangerously strained relations between Korean Americans and African Americans, its outcome only added to the tension. Ja Du, as punishment for the murder of Harlins, received probation and a \$500 fine, foreshadowing the outcome of the King trial.³⁷ For African Americans, the lenient sentence was yet another unfair outcome in a long line of unjust punishment. “It’s a travesty of justice,” declared a family friend of the Harlins.³⁸

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Outraged with the acquittal of the Rodney King police officers, the riots began. Unrest quickly reached many parts of South Central Los Angeles, primarily where Korean stores were doing business in Black communities.³⁹ The years of tension between Koreans and African Americans boiled over as rioters looted and burned Korean-owned stores across the city. Unprepared law enforcement was unable to respond to the violence for over three hours, leaving Koreans to defend their stores alone, prompting their use of military experience from Korea and firearms to combat rioters.⁴⁰ As one Korean resident described, “armed employees guarded her father’s store and tossed back out several gasoline bombs that had come crashing through the windows.”⁴¹ Koreans felt that “they were

³⁵ Del Barco, “Gas Station Cashier.”

³⁶ Kyung Lah, “The LA riots were a rude awakening for Korean-Americans,” *CNN*, April 29, 2017, accessed April 15, 2021, <https://www.cnn.com/2017/04/28/us/la-riots-korean-americans/index.html>.

³⁷ Sastry and Bates, “When LA Erupted.”

³⁸ Tracy Wilkinson and Frank Cilfford, “Korean Grocer Who Killed Black Teen Gets Probation,” *Los Angeles Times*, November 16, 1991, accessed May 9, 2021, <https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1991-11-16-mn-1402-story.html>.

³⁹ Chang, *Los Angeles*, 8.

⁴⁰ Sastry and Bates, “When LA Erupted.”

⁴¹ Mydans, “Koreans Rethink.”

deemed expendable. The reason was simple: a lack of political voice and political power.”⁴² This dramatic recognition created shifts in Korean American ideology, as Koreans realized that economic success alone was not a guarantee of their place in America.

In the aftermath, many LA Koreans found their property and lively hoods decimated, with almost a third of all Korean-owned businesses in Los Angeles damaged or destroyed.⁴³ In a study conducted by the Korean American Inter-Agency Council (KAIAAC) six months after the riots, “more than 50% of store owners face[d] a ‘very difficult’ financial situation.”⁴⁴ The devastating economic hardship revealed the deeper challenge that the community faced. Despite the model minority myth used to stereotype Koreans and other Asian immigrants as prosperous and successful, many Korean businessmen in Los Angeles were poor immigrants who would often remain in debt for years.⁴⁵ Ivan Light, the author of “Immigrant Entrepreneurs,” a study of Koreans in Los Angeles, acknowledged that “there will be some pulling out... but most [Korean owners] don’t have any options. That is their livelihood.”⁴⁶

Forced to reopen stores, Koreans depended on access money to rebuild and being allowed to reopen their stores, both factors which were challenging without political and governmental support. The mutual aid system among Korean businesses (who would normally have supported each other) was not enough to cover the \$400 million in damage produced by the riots.⁴⁷ This led them to seek financial aid from the government, to help revitalize the community. However, such support didn’t materialize. With loan payments and other “bureaucratic red tape” still in effect, the government’s failure to assist, acted as a “second riot” for many Koreans, re-traumatizing them through neglect.⁴⁸ In addition to limited support, the California government capitalized on the destruction of many liquor stores, requiring liquor store owners to go through public hearings before reopening their stores, further shining light on the vulnerability Koreans faced without political engagement in Los Angeles.⁴⁹

⁴² Lah, “The LA riots.”

⁴³ Mydans, “Koreans Rethink.”

⁴⁴ Carla Rivera, “Korean-Americans Looking Elsewhere After Riots,” *Los Angeles Times*, December 12, 1992, accessed May 8, 2021, <https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1992-12-24-mn-3574-story.html>.

⁴⁵ Mydans, “Koreans Rethink.”

⁴⁶ Mydans, “Koreans Rethink.”

⁴⁷ Mydans, “Koreans Rethink.”

⁴⁸ K. Connie Kang, “Korean Riot Victims Still Devastated, Study Finds,” *Los Angeles Times*, July 23, 1993, accessed May 8, 2021, <https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1993-07-23-me-15995-story.html>.

⁴⁹ Kang, “Korean Riot.”

The impact of these economic losses not only revealed the absence of political representation of Korean Americans, but it also influenced normal life for many Korean families.⁵⁰ The important cultural values of the community, education and stoicism were shaken by the effects of the riots. A study by the KAIAC in July of 1993 found that 15% of college-age Korean students had dropped out of school due to the riots with many other students pausing their studies to help their families. The immigrant belief in their “American Dream” was deeply challenged. The politically fraught situation also created a highly emotional atmosphere, colliding with the cultural norms brought from Korea. The immensity of the riots forced many to defy cultural practices of deference and stoicism and seek mental treatment. Dr. Man Chul Cho, a Korean therapist in Los Angeles, organized an outreach program to help riot victims work through these issues. Over 2,000 people signed up. In all, more than 500 out of 2,000 therapy patients of Dr. Cho were diagnosed with post-traumatic stress disorder.⁵¹ Up to this point, Koreans’ stiff, monocultural values brought them into conflict with African Americans, but this calamitous, multicultural disaster forced them to face that they were no longer in a single ethnic society, and therefore relying on their native complex social norms was inappropriate to dictate behaviors in this country. As many Koreans understood after the riots, communication with the Black community was key to begin closing the rift between the two groups.

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One of the most important lessons Korean Americans learned from riots was the influential role that African Americans played in Korean businesses and communities. Koreans realized that because of their Middleman position, conflict was inevitable when outreach and communication were not present. In several cases, Korean businessmen and African American customers used the tragic event of the riots to better understand each other’s culture and to diffuse tensions between the groups.⁵² In particular, initiatives to bring together the communities began, such as the efforts of David Ryu, a Korean student, and Nathan Redfern, a former Crips gang member, who worked together to lessen tensions between their communities by resolving conflicts between Korean store owners and Black customers, teaching classes in English as a second language, and providing mock citizenship exams for immigrants.⁵³

In combination, the changes brought about by the 5 days of rioting cemented the

⁵⁰ Kang, “Korean Riot.”

⁵¹ Banks, “The damage.”

⁵² Edward Taehan Chang, *Confronting Sa-i-gu: Twenty Years After the Los Angeles Riots*, UC Riverside Previously Published Works (2012), 21, https://yokcenter.ucr.edu/docs/other/11-12_Confronting_Sa-i-gu_Article.pdf.

⁵³ Parvini and Kim, “25 Years.”

period as one of the most influential events in Korean American history. Today, the riots carry the moniker of 사·오·구 (saigu), meaning 4/29, expressing similar weight to 9/11 in the broader American culture. The uprisings marked a turning point of Korean integration into American society, ultimately producing indelible political, cultural, and economic changes that deeply affected Korean immigrants' position in Los Angeles. In the years since the riots, Korean Americans have become far more politically active, with the first Korean congress member being elected a year after the riots.

While these advancements to ameliorate the conditions surrounding the riots are positive steps, the conditions that created the confrontational divide between two minority groups are still in play. The lack of immigrant integration in the US impacts many groups facing similar issues to west coast Korean immigrants, particularly those immigrant cultures which continue to serve in the Middleman Minority role (Armenians, Jews, Chinese, Hispanics) and create businesses in cultures outside of their own.⁵⁴ Recent hostilities against Asian Americans indicate persistent conflicts, and highlight the plight of non-white Americans. Numerous non-white immigrants in America are pressured by racial biases and innate cultural differences, drawing them in to conflict with various communities. The romanticization of the Korean struggle during the riots, primarily in the form of recent “rooftop Korean” memes proliferating online, has compelled many to see Koreans as solely victims of the riots and their defensive response as the model for other minorities.⁵⁵ This view myopically ignores the complexity of Korean immigrant interactions with other minority groups, which simmered beneath the surface for many years and contributed to the violence of the day. Moreover, while Koreans are often placed upon a racial pedestal, portrayed as the model minority, such narrow stereotypes ignore Korean suffering, demonize African Americans, and diminish the precarious state and vulnerabilities of minorities across the U.S. Ultimately, the role of Korean Americans before, during, and after the 1992 Los Angeles riots was not as heroes or villains, rather as small yet critical players in the larger systemic racial injustices that have plagued our nation since its founding.

⁵⁴ Douglas and Saenz, “Middleman Minorities;” Bonacich, “A Theory.”

⁵⁵ Korean gun use has also been used as evidence for pro-gun rhetoric of White Americans.

JAZZ

The Unrealized American Dream

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Milton Academy '22

IF THE AMERICAN DREAM IS defined as a quest for freedom and opportunity, jazz can be seen as a direct product of the African American community's struggle to realize this dream. Jazz is often called a uniquely American artform, but it would be more correct to say that jazz is the story of the African American experience, shaped by the struggles and experiences of African Americans and reflecting the fundamental social forces at work in American history. The African American community has often turned to music as an outlet for storytelling or creative expression, from slave songs that told of the sorrow of bondage to spirituals that expressed hope in a better world to come. Jazz tells the story of African Americans in the early part of the 20th century, when their pursuit of the American Dream culminated in the Great Migration.

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The American Dream encapsulates the freedom, hope, and light felt by the first settlers when reaching America and continues to represent American ideals as they once were. This era was one of optimism as African Americans fled to the North for new opportunities and created vibrant urban communities where physical segregation and population density promoted a sense of safety and pride. While racist attitudes prevented black musicians from participating in mainstream Eurocentric musical forms, this cultural segregation ultimately helped channel black creativity and musicality into the creation of their own style of music. Jazz music was at first demeaned by white critics but as it gained in popularity and became a commercial success, the white mainstream effectively co-opted the artform. Black musicians continued to be the source of musical innovation while being copied by white musicians or financially exploited by white music producers. While the white mainstream's adoption of jazz as an "American" art form allowed jazz to find a wider,

more diverse audience it was also a tragic situation in which many of African Americans' contributions were belittled or simply unrecognized. Jazz expresses a people's longing for, and belief in, the American Dream but remains an example of how that dream was not realized. The same patterns and the same unrealized dreams of equality and freedom can still be seen playing out today for African American artists in other spheres of American cultural life.

26

By the beginning of the 20th century, the optimism of Reconstruction had faded into the difficult reality of Jim Crow, a set of segregationist policies which trapped the majority of African Americans in the South in a sharecropping system which kept them poor. White southern landowners feared that abolishing slavery would result in a loss of economic power and therefore invested in a sharecropping system that not only ensured that African Americans would remain working for unjust compensation but also made it nearly impossible to be freed from white landowners. Sharecropping prevented African Americans from leaving the South while also denying enslaved people their own identities and histories. Many African Americans at the time did not have personal names and ended up giving each other nicknames once freed as a symbol of individuality. While slavery had been abolished, America still tolerated a climate of fear and violence against African American especially in the South where organizations like the Ku Klux Klan were active. In the North, fewer European immigrants were coming to America because of World War I which caused a significant labor shortage in industrial cities. Desperate to fill these vacancies, companies actively recruited African Americans from the South—hence, the Great Migration began. Between 1916 and 1970, an estimated 6 million African Americans left the rural South and moved to cities spanning the entire country but with focus on the North and Midwest. Some of the most active years for migration were between 1916 and 1930.¹ The Great Migration marked a passage of movement and relocation in the search of a better future. African Americans fled the south in huge numbers hoping to make a better future for themselves and their families. In the same way that European immigrants saw coming to America as offering the possibility of a better tomorrow, African Americans saw their move out of the South as giving them a similar opportunity to begin their quest to achieve American liberty.

Jim Crow laws in the South perpetuated social and cultural segregation between

¹ Isabel Wilkerson, "The Long-Lasting Legacy of the Great Migration," *The Smithsonian Magazine*, last modified September 2016, accessed March 31, 2021, <https://www.smithsonianmag.com/history/long-lasting-legacy-great-migration-180960118/>.

African and White Americans and dehumanized African Americans in all aspects of life. While the North was not free from segregation, it did not have the same types of legal restrictions on African Americans as in the South and this allowed for a more general mixing of people. The North was not ready for such a great influx of people and Black migrants had to build their own communities, many of them within white urban centers. Cities such as Chicago, New York, and Philadelphia are examples of traditionally white population centers that drew huge numbers of African American migrants and then became centers for African American culture and thought. Within these segregated communities, African Americans were able to connect and meet different African Americans who had felt the same sorrows and experienced the same evils. Living in an entirely Black community gave African Americans power and strength that had been stripped away from them during slavery. Finally, they were able to unite and build a new African American legacy in American history, which among other artistic endeavours included the creation of the first truly American music: jazz.

Early jazz reflected the optimism of the time for African Americans even in the face of continued racism and segregation. The South offered almost no opportunity for growth and change but migrating north offered the promise of a new future, an immigrant story which mirrored other similar journeys. Just as immigrants from Europe viewed their passage to America as a journey of hope for a better tomorrow, African Americans saw their departure from the South as the ticket to a bright future with “well paying jobs and the benefits of American’s civil liberties.”² Having to live separately from whites did not crush the optimism of this dream. In particular, after the deadly race riots that occurred in multiple cities in 1919, living in a large black enclave could in some ways provide a sense of security for African Americans who created what were essentially cities within cities. The segregated communities that African American communities formed in the North were often relatively affluent places where an emerging black middle class could experience greater freedom than in the larger white world. Duke Ellington describes the large black community on the South Side of Chicago in the 1920s as “a real us-for-we, we-for-us community...it was a community of men and women who were respected, people of dignity — doctors, lawyers, policy operators...everything and everybody but no junkies.” Communities like this helped to unify and empower African Americans. While African

² Burton W. Peretti, “The Creation of Jazz: Music, Race, and Culture in Urban America,” *American Music* 12, no. 2 (Summer 1994), https://www.jstor.org/stable/3052531?seq=2#metadata_info_tab_contents.

Americans who moved North were still living in a racist and segregated society, their lives looked markedly different and in general were better than they had been in the South. Families who had been sharecroppers and living at a subsistence level in isolated rural areas were now working class people in growing urban centers.

While many black communities remained on the shabby outskirts of mainstream society, other African American neighbourhoods existed as vibrant and affluent urban centers, notably Harlem. "Harlem [was and is] situated in the heart of Manhattan" and its physical centrality created a sense of inclusiveness and the possibility of equality.³ While Harlem was a Black community, residents who might have been unsophisticated sharecroppers in the South "soon... became New Yorkers."⁴ African Americans had been a rural community and now they were increasingly an urban one, with urban tastes and a new found sense of empowerment and possibility. This community provided the right audience for jazz, a musical form which spoke to their sense of freedom and pride in music which was distinctly African American. In this way, jazz was the product of social and demographic changes happening within the African American community and a direct result of this community's urbanization. While today segregation is seen as an unmitigated evil, for African Americans in the early 20th century, separation from the white mainstream gave space for the development of a strong and positive cultural identity and pride. Migrating North gave hope to African Americans and a way to reinvent themselves and make a new beginning even though they continued to live in separate, segregated communities.

In addition to physical segregation, African Americans were culturally segregated and excluded from mainstream culture. This exclusion forced black musicians to create genres where they could be free to express themselves and at the turn of the century, this expression took the form of jazz. Racial prejudice meant that African Americans were not seen as capable of participating in sophisticated pursuits like the fine arts. In addition, the vast majority of African Americans did not have access to the education or resources required to participate in the European art forms which defined what mainstream white America saw as culture, i.e. opera, classical music, literature. The majority of African Americans were illiterate and few African Americans could read musical notation. However, unlike classical music, operas, or literature, jazz was accessible to people even if they did not know how to read music or how to play a symphonic instrument. A.J.A Rogers comment-

³ James Weldon Johnson, "Black Manhattan," 1930, in *The Harlem Renaissance: A Brief History with Documents*, comp. Jeffery B. Ferguson.

⁴ Johnson, "Black Manhattan," in *The Harlem*.

ed on performance at the turn of the century explaining “Often wholly illiterate these (musicians) knew nothing about written music or composition but with minds like cameras they would ... ‘whip the ivories’ to marvellous chords and hidden racy meanings evoking the intense delight of their hearers.”⁵ Jazz centered around the idea of giving a voice to the experiences one had been through and claiming autonomy over their history. African Americans had previously been denied access into mainstream media and therefore were forging their own path in society through the exploration of jazz. Unlike music that was being composed in Europe and exported to America, jazz was being created in America by Americans and was evolving from slave work songs, traditional religious Black folk tunes, and ragtime. While white American musicians were focused on mastering European forms and expressing themselves within genres that were already recognized and respectable, African American musicians were forced to find new avenues for their creativity. They did this by drawing on what was already a rich tradition of black music and creating something that was new and spoke to the new condition of their community: free people with hope for a prosperous future. Excluded from white mainstream culture, African Americans were forced to create something for themselves and as jazz brought forth a new aesthetic it drew attention not only from appreciative African American audiences but piqued the interest of white Americans and people across the globe. At the same time that America was emerging as a political and economic power, jazz was contributing to America’s emergence as a cultural power as well.

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The Great Migration was not just a physical uprooting for African American people, it was also an emotional rite of passage in which African Americans experienced new feelings of confidence, pride, and joy. For many African Americans, Harlem of the 1920s and 1930s represented a completely new and vibrant vision of what the African American community could achieve and it proved to be a place where black talent and excellence were celebrated. The Harlem Renaissance was literally a rebirth for the African American people and while there were other vibrant African American communities across the country, Harlem held a special place in the African American imagination. African Americans in Harlem sought to reclaim control over their narrative as Harlem enjoyed “a time when freedom began to feel free.”⁶ Leading black thinkers and artists came to Harlem from

⁵ Alain Locke, *The Negro and His Music* (1936), accessed March 21, 2021, <https://babel.hathitrust.org/cgi/pt?id=mdp.39015009742886&view=1up&seq=5>.

⁶ Ferguson, Jeffery B. *The Harlem Renaissance: A Brief History with Documents*.

all over the country including Langston Hughes, Marcus Garvey, and Alain Locke. These and other leading figures of the Harlem Renaissance created plays, novels, poetry, music, and visual art which “protested vocally against racism and expressed identity on his or her own terms.”⁷ The optimism of African American migrants to the North and their vision of an African American culture which was both free and proud was reflected in the earliest examples of jazz music. Spirituals had been born out of the pain of enslavement and attempted to answer questions such as: “What happens to an enslaved person when she dies? What does it mean if her life has been so denigrated on earth? What ‘miracles of God are needed to get free?”⁸ In contrast, jazz was about building proudly on a long tradition of African American music while also expressing individuality, freedom, and joy.

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The non-acceptance of jazz by White Americans pigeonholed African Americans artists and the artform causing jazz to be looked down upon by not only White Americans but also elite African Americans. White Americans belittled the African American experience as an inferior form of music and not accepting jazz music into mainstream culture insisting that jazz “is merely a return to the humming, hand-clapping, or tomtom beating of savages.”⁹ As jazz became more popular, white print media began to cover and discuss the new found style of music and brought it upon themselves to criticize and speculate. The white upper class saw jazz as an abomination and viewed it as a noise that made dogs “burst forth loudly and dolorously.”¹⁰ Jazz was characterized by many white Americans as “invented by demons for torture of imbeciles” neglecting to appreciate the music’s sophistication and innovativeness in celebrating our country’s youth and heterogeneity.¹¹ White Americans were not only distraught that African Americans were creating popular music but were threatened by the power of the emotion and movement being brought forth by their music. Despite the negative attitudes of the white mainstream towards jazz, jazz music had begun to draw white fans who would come to otherwise black neighbourhoods to hear black musicians. The racial mixing in “black and tan” cabarets caused “frequent and heated

⁷ Ferguson, *The Harlem*.

⁸ Kaitlyn Greenidge, “Black Spirituals as Poetry and Resistance,” *The New York Times*, March 5, 2021, accessed April 1, 2021, <https://www.nytimes.com/2021/03/05/t-magazine/black-spirituals-poetry-resistance.html>.

⁹ Lawrence W. Levine, “Jazz and American Culture,” *The Journal of American Folklore* 102, no. 403 (January 1989), https://www.jstor.org/stable/540078?seq=1#metadata_info_tab_contents.

¹⁰ “Jazz Tunes Make the Dogs Howl,” *The New York Times*, April 25, 1920, accessed February 24, 2021, <https://timesmachine.nytimes.com/timesmachine/1920/04/25/112657548.html?pageNumber=125>.

¹¹ “Attack Immoral Art,” *The New York Times*, February 28, 1921, accessed February 24, 2021, <https://timesmachine.nytimes.com/timesmachine/1921/02/28/103551788.html?pageNumber=10>.

protests” and many Americans both black and white came to associate jazz with drinking, racial mixing, and other undesirable aspects of society.¹² In Chicago, Black church leaders discouraged their members from listening to jazz which mirrored the disapproval black “elites” had for the black migrants who had brought this new music to the city.¹³

One of the reasons that mainstream America did not initially recognize the artistry of jazz was that America was very much living in the shadow of Europe and most American institutions revered only the European tradition of classical music. This meant that upper class white Americans were encouraged to believe culture was synonymous with refinement and order; in contrast jazz was seen as “without the structure and form essential to music and poetry alike.”¹⁴ Jazz was accessible to many, spontaneous in feeling, and interactive while culture was defined as exclusive, orderly, and complex.¹⁵ Jazz appealed to a larger audience and was “frequently played in the midst of noisy, hand clapping, foot-stomping, dancing and gyrating audiences,” while truly “Cultural” music was sedate and had a clear separation of artist from audience. Certain elite parts of Black society also rejected jazz and tried to encourage “migrants (from the South) to admire, play, and listen to genteel white art music and to pursue formal musical instruction.”¹⁶ Although White Americans were searching for their national cultural identity, they rejected an identity built on inclusivity and diversity, and saw America’s mixture of cultures as a weakness rather than a strength—refusing to really consider Black music as valuable because of an “almost slavish devotion... to European ideals and standards.”¹⁷ Jazz had broken away from the Eurocentric cultural forms white America was bound to and for this it was both “praised and criticized for being almost completely out of the phase with the period’s concept of Culture.”¹⁸

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When white culture finally began to accept jazz, mainstream artists and audiences walked a fine line between appropriation and appreciation. By the end of 1920’s, jazz was being recorded by white musicians and being introduced into the mainstream with a distinctly white spin on jazz. White Americans had rejected the “hot and rough” sounds of jazz that were coming from African American communities and musicians but accepted the new smoother “sweet” style that White musicians had placed on the music. As many

¹² Amy Absher, *The Black Musician and the White City* (n.p.: University of Michigan Press, 2014), <http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctv3znzb4>.

¹³ Absher, *The Black*.

¹⁴ Levine, “Jazz and American.”

¹⁵ Levine, “Jazz and American.”

¹⁶ Peretti, “The Creation.”

¹⁷ Absher, *The Black*.

¹⁸ Levine, “Jazz and American.”

African Americans prepared to share their music with a larger audience, they would travel to white populated cities and listen to their music. African Americans quickly discovered that jazz was “clearly unlike the white man’s popular music” and realized that the only way to promote jazz in mainstream society would be to abandon jazz’s roots and conform to the new “sweet” style of jazz created by White Americans.¹⁹ While the abandonment of traditional jazz was detrimental for African American musicians it allowed them to cross over the cultural barrier and was imperative in making jazz profitable for not only white musicians but for African American musicians as well. However, diluting jazz for the mainstream culture destroyed the raw, genuine integrity of jazz and became “a plague, profitable but profligate, that [did] more moral harm than artistic good.”²⁰ In other situations, white musicians would have learned the songs and techniques by listening to black musicians in integrated jazz clubs but they received all the recognition and made money from recordings that were not an option for black artists at the time. The same inequality could be seen on the record production side of the music business. Race Records were labels that published black music but were owned by whites and which usually shamelessly exploited black musicians. They often withheld royalties from black artists and pressured artists to relinquish the rights to their own music. This same pattern of exploitation extended throughout the commercial side of the music world where clubs, theaters and dance halls that hired black bands were often owned by white businesspeople. Some black entrepreneurs like Harry Pace tried to launch black-owned record labels and Pace’s Black Swan label was initially very successful signing prominent black artists like Ethel Water, Louis Armstrong, and Jelly Roll Morton. Once it became clear, however, how much demand there was for “race” music and jazz, larger white owned labels moved into the market and pushed out black enterprises: Black Swan was eventually purchased and subsumed by the white owned Paramount Records.

The 1920’s and 1930’s were a time of great change for African American communities and these changes were mirrored in the musical innovation that produced jazz. The story of the African American experience post the Great Migration -- the hope as well as the continued burden of systemic racism in America -- can be heard, felt, and discovered through jazz of the same period. While it is an artform born out of a sense of optimism and opportunity it was also shaped by the much darker forces of segregation and cultural ap-

¹⁹ Lynne Seago, “From Potent to Popular: The Effects of Racism on Chicago Jazz 1920-1930,” Digital Commons @ IWU, last modified 2000, accessed April 1, 2021, <https://digitalcommons.iwu.edu/constructing/vol1/iss1/6/>.

²⁰ Seago, “From Potent.”

propriation. The story of jazz -- a story of deprivation giving birth to innovation and excellence that is followed by exploitation and appropriation -- is a story which we can see being repeated today. While there have been numerous white composers and musicians who have contributed to jazz's development, at its heart the story of jazz is the story of African Americans fighting to have their experiences and their culture recognized and appreciated. Prominent jazz musician, Wynton Marsalis, poses the question "If we don't understand what our constitution does, how will we understand what jazz is?" Marsalis draws a fundamental connection between jazz and our constitution. The two were built with the same principles of individual freedom and equality. Jazz builds a sense of inclusively and attracts a diverse group of people; however, ultimately, jazz is music by the people for the people.

RADICAL CHANGES, FEMINISM, AND DEMOCRATIC AUTONOMY

The Development of Kurdish Nationalism Through the Lens of
Turkish Nationalism

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FOLLOWING THE COLLAPSE OF THE Ottoman Empire, the borders of the new Turkish state were defined by the Treaty of Lausanne. Although the Kurds, an ethnic group of 30 to 40 million, were promised a state, this was never realized, the majority of their homeland being subsumed into the Turkish state. At the same time, Turkish nationalism was just taking hold. Kemal Ataturk and Abdullah Öcalan, the two father figures of Turkish and Kurdish nationalism, clashed as their goals of nation-building conflicted and led to violence on both sides. Though Kurdish nationalism developed in initially violent ways in newly Kemalist Turkey—leading to Turkish and Kurdish nationalism catalyzing the development of the other—through radical ideology, feminism, and democratic autonomy, Kurdish groups, with an evolving nationalism, ultimately struggled to defend the rights of their own people to exist while garnering increasingly hostile resistance.

Kurdish nationalism first rose to prominence with revolts in the early 20th century in Turkey. Though Kurdish leaders initially supported Kemal during the Turkish War of Independence and the founding of the Turkish republic, this sentiment quickly changed.¹ As sweeping secularization and centralizing reforms took place in newly Kemalist Turkey, the Muslim-majority Kurds reacted negatively, revolting. The most prominent rebellion, the Sheikh Sait rebellion of 1925, broke out in Kurdish majority southeast Turkey.² The revolt's namesake, Sheikh Sait, was the head of the Naqshbandi order, a group influential

¹ Robert W. Olson and William F. Tucker, "The Sheikh Sait Rebellion in Turkey (1925): A Study in the Consolidation of a Developed Uninstitutionalized Nationalism and the Rise of Incipient (Kurdish) Nationalism," *Die Welt des Islams*, 1978, 199, <https://doi.org/10.2307/1570466>.

² Olson and Tucker, "The Sheikh," 195.

in Kurdish districts. As a tribal leader his influence became a “real threat to the Ankara government when he agreed to head a rebellion.”³ These revolts were soon suppressed by the new Republic’s army, and the Kurds were subsequently cautious about exercising further rebellion.⁴ These revolts were meant to bring about a Kurdish nation state to protect their interests from an increasingly centralized and dictatorial state in which their traditional identity in both ethnic and religious aspects would be threatened.⁵

After this initial uptick in nationalism, a new Kurdish leader and thinker with violent aspirations arose and began to influence many in the region. Born in southeastern Turkey in 1948, Öcalan became involved with Marxism in university,⁶ eventually founding the PKK, the Kurdistan Workers’ Party. In 1977, he wrote a manifesto, “The National Road to the Kurdish Revolution,” and began training guerillas after fleeing to Syria in 1979.⁷ In 1984, as PKK militants organized into camps in northern Iraq, they began their armed campaign against Turkey, later enacted terrorism against “government installations and officials, Turks living in the country’s Kurdish regions, Kurds accused of collaborating with the government, foreigners, and Turkish diplomatic missions abroad.”⁸ Consequently, under Öcalan’s leadership from 1984 to 1999, there was “heavy bloodshed for the PKK[, as well as] Turkey,” as the group allegedly kidnapped tourists and ordered the murder of numerous civilians. Soon, however, Kurdish movements in Syria began to outshadow those in Iraq, as then-president Asad embraced the PKK before its expulsion in 1998, hosting “at least 8,000 to 10,000 ‘armed supporters’ there.”⁹ This left a lasting effect on the new Syrian branch of the organization, one which would eventually lead to the development of the autonomous region of Rojava. In 1999, Öcalan was captured and imprisoned, his trial and death sentence for treason—later commuted to life imprisonment due to Turkey’s E.U. ambitions—being met with protest from Kurds. Though its leader was imprisoned, the fight for Kurdish liberation did not end as the PKK continued its attacks amid multiple

³ Olson and Tucker, “The Sheikh,” 195.

⁴ Olson and Tucker, “The Sheikh,” 199.

⁵ Umit Cizre Sakallıoglu, “Kurdish Nationalism from an Islamist Perspective: The Discourses of Turkish Islamist Writers,” *Journal of Muslim Minority Affairs* 18, no. 1, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13602009808716394>.

⁶ Richard McHugh, “Abdullah Öcalan,” in *Britannica School*, <https://school-eb-com.ezproxy.milton.edu/levels/high/article/Abdullah-%C3%96calan/603840>.

⁷ McHugh, “Abdullah Öcalan.”

⁸ Helicon, “Workers’ Party of Kurdistan,” in *The Hutchinson Unabridged Encyclopedia with Atlas and Weather Guide* (n.p., 2018), http://ezproxy.milton.edu:2048/login?url=https://search.credoreference.com/content/entry/heliconhe/workers_party_of_kurdistan/0?institutionId=8845.

⁹ Ofra Bengio, “Reclaiming National Identity in Kurdish School Textbooks,” *Middle East Institute*, 363.

ceasefires which were called off.

As Kurdish nationalism arose in the form of radical groups, Turkish nationalist developing in tandem led to the violent suppression of Kurdish aspirations; Kurdish nationalism consequently became less violent to protect the interests of the Kurdish people as the two incompatible ideologies interacted with and strengthened one another. For example, the PKK's radical social ideology sought "freedom from colonialism and class divisions, thus opposing both Turkish government oppression and the traditional hierarchy of Kurdish society."¹⁰ At the same time, when Atatürk strived to eliminate religion from daily life in an attempt to modernize, his attempt consequently "[eliminated] the unity which Islam provided among fellow Muslims, [providing] the motivation for the rise of nationalist sentiment among the Kurds."¹¹ Kemalism led to ethnicity replacing religion as the unifying factor, leaving no room for plurality. This pushed the Turkish republic, dominated by secular nationalism, to attempt to erase the Kurdish identity, as is demonstrated by the Ankara government referring to the Kurds as "mountain Turks."¹² This attempt to remove an identity resulted in violence which paled in comparison to Kurdish attacks and only deepened support for Kurdish nationalism; 40,000 people, mostly Kurds, have been killed since the PKK's armed resistance in 1984 by Turkey in ways described as "pogrom-like violence... [including] chemical gassings, bombings, forced relocations, and the razing of entire villages."¹³ As PKK fighter "Fingerless Zeki" expressed, "The main reason for our struggle is so that we can live on our own soil and win the right to live as human beings. It's not to dominate someone else's land."¹⁴ As the two competing nationalisms further developed, Kurdish goals also shifted from violence and radicalism in light of heavy repression to better achieve its goals. No longer seeking a nation state but rather increased autonomy, the PKK transitioned in the 1990's from a "militant, patriarchal organization [along] Marxist-Leninist lines" one which valued feminism and socialism.¹⁵ While some of these some of these values, such as feminism, first seemed in line with Kemalism in Tur-

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¹⁰ Helicon, "Workers' Party."

¹¹ Sakallioğlu, "Kurdish Nationalism."

¹² Olson and Tucker, "The Sheikh," 200.

¹³ Debbie Bookchin, "How My Father's Ideas Helped the Kurds Create a New Democracy," *The New York Review*, June 2018, 2, accessed November 19, 2020, <https://www.nybooks.com/daily/2018/06/15/how-my-fathers-ideas-helped-the-kurds-create-a-new-democracy/>.

¹⁴ "An Interview with PKK Leader Abdullah Öcalan," video, Youtube, posted by Journeyman Pictures, 1998, accessed December 4, 2020, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cMfJRnWu52Y>.

¹⁵ Bookchin, "How My Father's," 3.

key, the revolutionary values became irreconcilable as Kurds threatened Turkish cohesion with radical actions stemming from a need to protect their own interests against Turkish repression, thus further catalyzing both movements.

Various Kurdish groups also valued feminism in society and implemented this in policy, though for revolutionary motivations different from Turkey's goals of modernization, posing a threat to Turkish nationalism. When Kemal sought to implement feminist ideology, his ultimate goal was to bring Turkey into the 'civilized,' modern world, away from its Ottoman roots. The Kurds, however, regarded feminism as a form not of modernization but of revolution; Öcalan wrote that "the 5,000-year-old history of civilization is essentially the history of the enslavement of woman" and that this enslavement was "closely linked to the rise within a society of hierarchical and statist power."¹⁶ Thus, to implement these feminist ideas was for men and women alike to overthrow the power of not only gender hierarchies but existing hierarchies and the Turkish state, a grave threat to a new nation already reacting harshly to other external threats it faced. The connection between female subjugation and hierarchical and statist power also revealed how feminism influenced Kurds to evolve their objectives from an independent state to increased autonomy. In addition, one male Kurdish PKK fighter expressed that "the liberation of women; their right to express themselves; and their need to play a role in the general development of society" were important to the PKK.¹⁷ Feminism's role was clearly to create a society in which women held just as much power as men; their liberation would require radical changes that would threaten Turkey. For example, harsh repression from Turkey that Kurdish women in Turkey and Syria faced in the late 1980s and 90's prompted many to join the PKK, where they made up a third of the force. Öcalan's accommodations for these women's demands for equal rights—a separate militia and institutions—reinforced that feminism was not theoretical but actively promoted and put into policy.¹⁸ Indeed, feminist ideals were pervasive and engrained into the provisional constitution of the Rojava region of northern Syria, which explicitly guarantees women's "inviolable right to participate in political, social, economic and cultural life."¹⁹ Women's councils in the region could even "override decisions

¹⁶ Bookchin, "How My Father's," 7.

¹⁷ "An Interview," video.

¹⁸ Bookchin, "How My Father's," 7.

¹⁹ "Charter of the Social Contract," Peace in Kurdistan, last modified January 2014, accessed December 7, 2020, <https://web.archive.org/web/20150616161409/http://peaceinkurdistancampaign.com/resources/rojava/charter-of-the-social-contract/>.

made by other councils when the matter specifically concerns a women's interests."²⁰ The Kurds' implementation of feminism as a part of their nationalism was not only to provide a better society for women, but indicative of their radical rejection of all hierarchical power and centralized, state power, thus exacerbating the threat to Turkish nationalism with its feminism being for modernization.

Furthermore, the concept of grassroots democracy, intertwined with notions of socialism and feminism, manifested in 'democratic autonomy' and 'communalism' as Kurds rejected the hierarchical nature of a nation state; developments in Rojava underscored the incompatibility of Kurdish aspirations within Turkey and exemplified the equitable values a wholly independent Kurdistan could be based on. Recently, in mostly Kurdish Rojava—under increased autonomy not possible under Turkey's harsh suppression—policies aimed to forge a radical society where all were equal and with no hierarchies or nation state. Indeed, this concept of democratic autonomy signified a shift as the PKK no longer supported the notion of a nation-state despite having previously fought for one. Nonetheless, the concept still posed a threat to existing states; for example, the Charter of Rojava proclaims that they are "led by principles of equality and environmental sustainability... [in] building a society free from authoritarianism, militarism, [and] centralism," in contradiction of earlier authoritarian and centralization during Kemalism in Turkey.²¹ Indeed, the revolutionary way of "wrestling back control from the central state" led to the incompatibility of Kurdish insurgence within Turkish borders with the regime's intense nationalism, as the communalist, people-oriented nature would threaten centralizing and authoritarian governments and nation states.²² Moreover, in the cantons of Northern Syria, "multi-ethnic neighborhood assemblies" had influence and power, and a "non-hierarchical, non-sectarian...outlook and a cooperative economy built on anti-capitalist principles" were emphasized in stark contrast with growing ethnocentrism and capitalism in Turkey.²³ The democratic councils and communalist nature of democratic autonomy were a slight departure from earlier calls for a nation state, as Öcalan's characterized the nation state as the "most dangerous instrument in history," due its potential for repression and violence as in the case of the Kurds. Kurdish democratic autonomy, incompatible with Turkey's nationalism, flourished in Syria in light of the infeasibility of an independent Kurdistan.

²⁰ Bookchin, "How My Father's," 7.

²¹ "Charter of the Social," Peace in Kurdistan.

²² Bookchin, "How My Father's," 7.

²³ Bookchin, "How My Father's," 3.

Despite Kurdish nationalism's initially violent development in early 20th century Turkey, where Turkish and Kurdish nationalism catalyzed the development of the other, Kurdish groups ultimately struggled to defend their interests and rights of their own people to exist and evolved their nationalism through radical ideology, feminism, and democratic autonomy against increasing resistance. Amidst its counterpart of Turkish nationalism, whose harsh, authoritarian nature left no room for the minority group, Kurds have not fully realized their ambitions. While facing severe repression from nations such as Turkey in more recent years with an offensive by President Erdogan's into Rojava following multiple peace talks, Kurds' fight for liberation has continued for decades. Optimistically, policies in autonomous Rojava stand as a beacon of hope to educate a new generation of revolutionary Kurds that may someday secure the ever-so-lacking rights for the stateless group.

SYLLOGISTIC HYSTERIA

How the CIA and the HUAC Propelled Public Fear of Communism

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*"The mood McCarthy seized on can almost be expressed as a syllogism.
America is so powerful. Yet things are not going as we want them to. Ergo, we
are being betrayed."¹*

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IN THE POST-WORLD WAR II ERA, the growing political and social ideology of communism was no unfamiliar concept to the American public. Indeed, the fear of radical anarchists and Bolsheviks dominating US labor unions had begun before World War I. A primary cause of the First Red Scare was nationalism. Nationalism created unity within a sovereign nation by encouraging the public to embrace a civic identity based on culture and politics. During the First Red Scare, Americans feared those who threatened the robust country's national identity: far-left extremists. Moreover, the Bolshevik revolution, aiming to establish a communist regime, emanated in the Soviet Union, an ally of the US, around the 1920s. This current event and the rising nationalism in America provoked such concern that led to domestic, anticommunist federal investigations and prejudice towards any radical leftists. The worry soon subsided, but following WWII, as American nationalistic standards grew again, previous fears of communist subversion returned and ignited an explosion of propaganda, political intimidation, and manipulation in US political culture. The Second Red Scare was deemed far more complex as America's international

¹ Godfrey Hodgson, *America in Our Time: From World War II to Nixon--What Happened and Why* (n.p.: Princeton University Press, 2005), 37.

relationship with the Soviet Union became volatile. When this recalcitrant foreign issue confronted the victorious, invulnerable United States post World War II, the public was subjected to the consequence of great expectations: an illusion of omnipotence. Fear and doubt grew as the Soviet's became more antagonized and exaggerated proposing a threat to American standards within the public sphere. During the Second Red Scare, politician Joseph McCarthy utilized the growing communist concern as an opportunity by conducting unfair investigations on alleged communists. This enduring, boisterous practice was known as McCarthyism, and it lasted years due to the doubtful, anticommunist environment. Many observed that such fear capitalized on by Senator McCarthy was assumed by international policy and relations or the disappointment of high expectations; however, American domestic politics and government organizations were also capable of fueling this concern through excessive controversies and encapsulated feelings of national betrayal and weakness. Following World War II in the United States of America, public fear and syllogistic inquisitions emphasized by the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) and the House of Un-American Activities (HUAC) created the perfect environment for Joseph McCarthy to expand upon and provoke mass hysteria.

The CIA's position in the American government granted the agency unequivocal public trust during the Red Scare, further providing the CIA with unbridled influence that concealed their many errors and manipulations. The National Security Act of 1947 reinforced the implemented foreign policy along with military improvements as World War II ended and the United States and USSR's relationship worsened. The act created the CIA with a mission "to correlate and evaluate intelligence relating to the national security, and provide for the appropriate dissemination of such intelligence within the Government."² This description demonstrated the importance of foreign affairs to the agency's mission. Foreign affairs during that time concerned the increasing tensions between the US and the Soviet Union; therefore, with the escalating fear of Soviet espionage, the CIA maintained a position of power that possessed the ultimate trust of Americans despite the agency's eventual interference with many individual lives. During the Cold War, as public unease intensified, the CIA gained a more authoritative reputation as it became involved in domestic media, kindling a climate of fear and propaganda. Gerald R. Ford exemplified these efforts, noting that "The CIA would come in and paint the most scary picture possible

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² "Mission and Vision," CIA.gov, accessed May 7, 2021, <https://www.cia.gov/about/mission-vision/#:~:text=At%20the%20CIA%2C%20our%20mission,directed%20by%20the%20president%3B%20and>.

about what the Soviets would do to us—we were going to be second-rate; the Soviets were going to be Number One.”³ Ford articulated that the agency villainized the Soviets to the American public, targeting the valued mindset of America’s overriding nation; trepidation would be provoked by the CIA strategically manipulating people’s high expectations and threatening disappointment. Their compelling influence over American culture was present in the various unwarranted investigations conducted and allegations made. These explorations disregarded the privacy and constitutional rights of many civilians; however accusation after accusation was pursued by the CIA for years. The Lattimore Case was a prime example of the agency’s partisan allegations. People suspected Owen Lattimore for his involvement in Soviet espionage when he booked a passage to France, allegedly planning a trip to the USSR. The CIA swiftly became entailed and messaged the State Department saying: “Owen Lattimore will leave on a trip to the USSR via Air France June twenty-one, nineteen fifty-two, arriving Paris June twenty-two, nineteen fifty-two. Date of travel to Kiev and Moscow via aero/flot are open. his tickets have been paid for and have been forwarded to him.”⁴ In a fragile time, the CIA claiming such a bold statement on supposed communist activity caused chaos in the public. Everything happened quickly, hence believable, and poor Lattimore’s individual was alienated by the government and the people. Nonetheless, on June 27, the New York Times released an article commenting, “A high State Department official said today that the Central Intelligence Agency had represented a false report that Prof. Owen Lattimore had planned to visit Moscow as a confirmed fact,” and the CIA’s proof derived from “‘raw and unevaluated data,’ as C.I.A. officials had asserted privately.”⁵ This quote from the article depicts the CIA’s flaws, although the agency was deemed believable in an impactful position; the false reports and sketchy data commonly released from the CIA succeeding their many corrupt allegations were never questioned amidst hysterical times. Additionally, the agency emphasized on fear by keeping their information discreet. Mentioning the bare, unviable data remained a private matter by the officials. It was up to their reputation whether people would trust that evidence, and in the agency’s authoritative position monitoring communist activity, it was likely the public would. All the different factors of secrecy, trust, and emphasis on fear that pertained to the CIA further applied to other domestic organizations and primarily the HUAC, a thriving

³ Tim Weiner, *Legacy of Ashes: The History of the CIA* (n.p.: Doubleday, 2007), 191.

⁴ Robert P. Newman, “Red Scare in Seattle, 1952: The FBI, the CIA, and Owen Lattimore’s ‘Escape’,” *The Historian* 48, no. 1 (November 1985): 4, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/24445658>.

⁵ Newman, “Red Scare,” 10.

committee with widespread impact in the McCarthy era.

The House Un-American Activities Committee's initial purpose of probing communist influence in the United States extended people's trust towards the dependable committee and fear that kept the HUAC active despite their inequitable treatment of witnesses. As the spread of communism escalated, in 1938, the committee was created with a primary purpose of scrutinizing alleged communists "on the part of private citizens, public employees and organizations."⁶ The granted control of the HUAC provided the power to completely disrupt a business or interfere with an individual's life without governmental punishment. In terms of antagonizing communism and persuading public opinion, the "HUAC attempted to instil a public fear of insidious 'un-Americanism' by casting itself as the Constitutional protector of Americanism's core values."⁷ The quote illustrates a method the committee used placing itself in an invulnerable position where people recognized the HUAC's fighting for American ideals and could be easily persuaded to distress threats of the national government: un-Americanism. The House, with its prime target as communism, gained a high reputation amidst the Red Scare, whilst the HUAC demonstrated skeptical, unlawful behaviors when questioning witnesses. Walter Gellhorn commented on the unfair system acknowledging that "the committee [had] persisted in spreading baseless or prejudiced testimony of sensational and irresponsible character all over the record and the press without giving those charged a fair chance to reply."⁸ In this quote, Gellhorn remarks on the committee's flaw: the unfair treatment of those being questioned which may result in critical information missing. An example of the HUAC's defective inquiries was the Alger Hiss Case where former Communist Party member Whittaker Chambers—who admitted his involvement and joined the FBI after he left—adamantly accused American government official, Alger Hiss, for committing espionage. Scholar Robert K. Carr noted that if Chambers was questioned in a more vigorous attitude by the HUAC, the espionage hearings could "have uncovered significant bits of information concerning espionage in the government service that came to light only much later during the two Hiss Trials."⁹ In such a position of power, the Committee was depended upon to provide various pieces

⁶ "House Un-American Activities Committee," Trumanlibrary.gov, accessed May 5, 2021, <https://www.trumanlibrary.gov/education/presidential-inquiries/house-un-american-activities-committee>.

⁷ Ruth Martin, "Operation Abolition: Defending the Civil Liberties of the 'Un-American,' 1957–1961," *Journal of American Studies* 47, no. 4 (November 2013): 2, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/24485874>.

⁸ Walter Gellhorn, "Report on a Report of the House Committee on Un-American Activities," *Harvard Law Review* 60, no. 8 (October 1947): 42, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/1335294>.

⁹ Robert K. Carr, "The Un-American Activities Committee," *The University of Chicago Law Review* 18, no. 3 (Spring 1951): 16, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/1597778>.

of information; however, as proven in this quote, the HUAC contradicted the purpose of an ideal, mature organization who treated witnesses fairly. In terms of opposition, many failed to revoke the House due to its ultimate trust in the fearful environment. San Franciscans for Academic Freedom and Education (SAFE) was an organization contesting the HUAC, and on July 22, SAFE indicated their goals to rescind the committee: one being to “marshal sufficient community concern about the Committee’s purposes and procedures to effectively confine the Committee to its proper legislative functions and to prevent any infringement of First Amendment rights.”¹⁰ SAFE was cognizant of the HUAC’s contravention towards constitutional rights, and SAFE hoped for the revocation of a committee violating citizen’s virtue despite the heightened fear of communism. Consequently, Arthur Bierman, a leader of SAFE, voiced, “It was practically impossible to get anyone to come out against [HUAC],... The fear was visceral,” and he described individual’s reactions saying, “People would turn white. They would stutter.”¹¹ Bierman’s interpretation encapsulates how fear allowed the HUAC to run its course without prevention. Opposition to the committee failed as the HUAC continued for years emphasizing public doubt with methods of instilling fear and using their power to conduct unfair investigations. The Committee’s effect on the environment was similar to the CIA’s: they created hysteria in political culture through the cases they initiated, and this chaos allowed for one man to utilize the atmosphere as an opportunity.

The radical agitation and fear in the anticommunist environment presented the ideal opportunity for Joseph McCarthy to flourish and fuel the hysteria. McCarthyism outlined the volatile atmosphere in US political culture comprehending indications of far-left activity. Countless accusations by apprehensive civilians, opportunists, and even friends and family were encouraged by the country’s domestic subversion, and the various cases, particularly the Rosenberg Trial and the Hollywood Ten, strongly depicted the hysteria and manipulation of the McCarthy era with emphasis of the CIA and HUAC. The Rosenberg Trial involved Ethel and Julius Rosenberg existing as alleged communists with plans to commit espionage. Ethel was accused by her own brother, David Greenglass, of containing confidential information about Soviet atomic bombs, although Greenglass’s assertion lacked fine evidence to support his claims. Yet, in an era of dismay, the Rosenbergs

¹⁰ Joshua Paddison, “Summers of Worry, Summers of Defiance: San Franciscans for Academic Freedom and Education and the Bay Area Opposition to HUAC, 1959-1960,” *California History* 78, no. 3 (Fall 1999): 6, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/25462565>.

¹¹ Paddison, “Summers of Worry,” 6.

received a trial anyway and not a fair one. The only piece of evidence that correlated with the conspiracy of Rosenberg's criminal acts was the description of an atomic bomb being transported to the Soviet Union.¹² Immediately, people began accusing the couple of betraying the US, and propaganda backed the public's retorts; in a New York Times article, U.S. Attorney Myles Lane asserted, "If the crime with which she, Ethel, is charged had not occurred, perhaps we would not have the present situation in Korea."¹³ In this quote, the reference to the Korean War, a war destined to fuel the public's concern of communism coming to America, exaggerated and antagonized Ethel and Julius, fabricating their ambitions and negatively adjusting the public's reaction towards the Rosenberg's cause. What about the trial seized historians' attention was the death sentence. Ethel's family deceived her and the government pressured her, and in the Foley Court, 1951, Judge Kaufman stated, "The defendants... placed their devotion to their cause above their own personal safety and were conscious that they were sacrificing their children should their misdeeds be detected."¹⁴ After this statement, the Judge announced the Rosenberg's sentence as death by the electric chair. He provided reasons for the execution by exploiting their personal life decisions and their devotions, painting them as traitors in simple terms of betraying their children. The Daily News released an article about the death sentence labeling the couple as spies, further emphasizing the conspiracy of their espionage to the public.¹⁵ Evidence of the fearful environment was supported by a single conspiracy that convicted two Americans to death. David Greenglass, the informant of Ethel's alleged intentions, received little questioning towards the reasons of his incrimination, and, similar to the HUAC's seldom questioning of Chambers, vital information was left behind containing potential evidence of Greenglass's guilt. Propaganda labeling Ethel and Julius as antagonists manipulated people's opinions and justified the sentence, resembling the CIA's influence over public doubt. Traits of the CIA and HUAC in the environment of fear shaped the trial's proceedings and sparked the notorious conviction of the Rosenberg couple, and unjust inquisitions alike continued, especially in Hollywood.

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In the McCarthy era, the Hollywood industry exhibited numerous investigations imposed upon individuals, harming careers and threatening citizen's constitutional rights.

¹² Elli Meeropol and Beth Schneider, "The Ethel Rosenberg Story," *Off Our Backs* 5, no. 8 (September/October 1975): 2, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/25772313>.

¹³ Meeropol and Schneider, "The Ethel," 3.

¹⁴ Meeropol and Schneider, "The Ethel," 3.

¹⁵ Meeropol and Schneider, "The Ethel," 3.

A particular case that was prominent to the public was the Hollywood Ten: ten people, employees of the filmmaking organization, refused to answer questions regarding their alleged past association with the Communist party. Alas, the Hollywood Ten were imprisoned after citing their constitutional right to freedom of speech and assembly, justifying their unforgiven silence. While their actions emphasized Americanism, their conviction demonstrated the unjust atmosphere penetrating constitutional protection. The irony was the HUAC's presumed preservation of American values against un-Americanism, although the silent individuals who possessed constitutional rights were imprisoned for the supposed assertion of communist affiliation. Not only the Hollywood Ten, but many other employee's faced similar treatment by the government system. American actress, Gale Sondergaard, was also convicted, and in a letter to the HUAC chairman, she expressed "I believe in freedom of speech and religion and association as described in our first amendment," and added, "unfortunately our present Supreme Court has not seen fit to spell out its legal availability to us in our own days."¹⁶ In her letter, Gale recognized the Supreme Court's failure to acknowledge the rights of individuals to speak as they wanted. This quote portrays the government during the McCarthy era: careless of individual values and motivated by public fear. In this environment, opportunists further targeted individuals; within the industry, people betrayed each other's back, throwing out allegations and using the biased government's aid. In the same letter, when she was accused, Gale described her understanding of these actions saying, "today I read that this particular inquisition is not directed against the industry but is directed at individuals... employers, having been guaranteed that they would not be personally involved, have given the committed carte blanche to attack individuals to their own purposes."¹⁷ Gale's input, similar to the Hollywood Ten, depicted injustice under a system that capitalized on justice and fairness within itself. Individuals had a disadvantage. However, people, such as employers, possessed the advantage to accuse someone without being interrogated. This idea provided opportunists in the Hollywood industry with great ascendancy. The multiple Hollywood occurrences displayed how certain information would stay discreet and questions would be avoided allowing accusations and unjust interrogations to flourish under the emphasis of government committees and agencies.

¹⁶ "Letter to HUAC Chairman," photograph, History.House.gov, accessed April 26, 2021, <https://history.house.gov/HouseRecord/Detail/15032449720>.

¹⁷ "Letter to HUAC."

Inquisitions of domestic subversion and allegations of Soviet espionage and communist affiliations were mobilized by the CIA and HUAC in an unjust manner. The organizations utilized public fear to their advantage and conducted unfair investigations destroying careers and grasping the attention of opportunists. Joseph McCarthy, the man who—at the time—gained a great reputation in the government for throwing out these accusations, portrayed similar traits to the HUAC and the CIA. In a journal article concerning the CIA, it was noted that “there was no naive acceptance of official statements for McCarthy; the truth had to be hidden, conspiratorial, and manipulated by the Kremlin.”¹⁸ This description of McCarthy illustrated his idiosyncrasy that people seldom opposed but respected for the sake of the country. His personality aligned with that of the CIA and HUAC: manipulative, propaganda-based, and untruthful, and these destructive traits allowed for biased investigations without question. Throughout the Red Scare, the distinction of America’s domestic politics emphasizing this bias and doubt was unrecognizable due to fear and chaos. People could not help but devote unequivocal certitude due to the omnipresent manipulation of organizations and committees claiming they would protect American interests and uphold standards. The inspections of alleged communists and spies were conniving of individual lives as depicted through the HUAC’s prejudiced behaviors in questioning. Yet, the public mindset remained warped by the confidential truth as the CIA used unevaluated evidence. It was this emphasized fear that authorized the Rosenberg Case and the Hollywood industry accusations. The concern of America’s high expectations facing disappointment to Soviet espionage and people’s national identity becoming flawed aided the hysteria. With the CIA and HUAC propelling unease, the public permitted this irrationality with a blind eye. Conclusions drawn from biases and raw information incited a mood to be defined as a syllogism.

¹⁸ Simon Willmetts, “Quiet Americans: The CIA and Early Cold War Hollywood Cinema,” *Journal of American Studies* 47, no. 1 (February 2013): 6, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/23352510>.

A ROADMAP FOR AUTHORITARIANS

The Rise of Huey Long

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The premise of Sinclair Lewis's classic 1936 novel *It Can't Happen Here* is focused on Berzelius "Buzz" Windrip, a charismatic and power-hungry politician who promises to restore the country to prosperity and greatness, and to give each citizen \$5,000 per year, portraying himself as a champion of traditional American values. Having won the 1936 election on this populist platform, Windrip immediately outlaws dissent, incarcerates political enemies, and implements a host of other authoritarian policies, all the while maintaining the support of the populace. The novel has long been praised for its realistic portrayal of how democracy can fall with the consent of the people, and many parallels have been drawn between its storyline and the rise of fascism in Europe and Japan. However, Sinclair's main inspiration for the book was not from across the Atlantic; it came instead from one of the most prominent American politicians of the 1930s: Huey Long.

Huey Long grew up one of nine children in the impoverished Winn Parish, Louisiana—a hotbed of populist and socialist sentiment, and an area that had been a Union stronghold in the Civil War. He excelled in schoolwork, but this excellence was not a reflection of interest. In fact, "Huey never had much patience for school. In 1910... Winnifred High School expelled him."¹ After his expulsion, Huey became a traveling salesman, sharpening his wit and becoming an effective peddler, often employing scripture and shoddy health advice to sell shortening to housewives. Long then went through a flurry of occupations before finally deciding to go to law school. By the time Long, having graduated early, stepped on the train back to Winn Parish, he had already decided that law would be

¹ Richard White, *Kingfish: The Reign of Huey P. Long* (Random House, 2006), 8.

his stepping stone to a greater ambition: politics. As he told his wife during this time, he “planned to run first for a minor office, then for governor of the state, then-senator, and finally, for president of the United States.”² Faithful to his word, Huey ran for state railroad commissioner, narrowly defeated his opponent, and two years later ran for but failed to win the governor’s office. Finally, after another four years, he won the position in a landslide, much to the chagrin of the Democratic party establishment. Up to this point, one could effectively characterize the story of Huey Long as one of triumph for democracy: an underdog procuring the support of the people and challenging the political establishment through tireless campaigning. However, upon obtaining power, Long—soon to be known as “Kingfish”—would systematically dismantle the very institutions that led him to power. Through his popular and disruptive cult of personality, populist and inflammatory rhetoric, and his control and suppression of the press, Huey Long’s tenure demonstrates how democratic institutions can be torn down with the consent of the people.

One way Huey Long gathered and maintained support among the people was his deliberate establishment of a contagious cult of personality. From a young age, Long exhibited a knack for influencing the people around him. As he once recalled in an interview, he and his friends in school had once created a “secret society,” through which he became “part of a sort of circle that would control things, laying down certain rules the students had to follow. If the students obeyed faculty rules, Huey and his followers would keep them off the baseball or debate teams.”³ This was not just a minor game played between friends; the ‘society’ would often clash with faculty, prompting Huey to be reprimanded. In response to the faculty’s pushback, the 16-year-old Long wrote an open letter insulting the faculty and the principal, which he handed around the school and town, leading to his prompt expulsion. While characterizing this episode of the Kingfish’s life as an example of a cult of personality would be a stretch, the saga does demonstrate his unique ability to bring the people around him into his orbit, a skill he would go on to make great use of throughout his political career.

This situation also exposed another Long’s tendency to use institutions of power to rally people behind him. In the end, a group of teens held together by nothing more than one student’s charisma was no match for the school’s faculty, but even after he was expelled, Huey was not done. He walked around Winn parish with a handwritten petition, calling for the principal’s termination. Through his smooth-talking alone, he was able to

² White, *Kingfish*, 12-13.

³ White, *Kingfish*, 8.

convince a majority of townsfolk to sign it, getting the principal fired, and Huey the last laugh. He was able to win the common folk over to his side with only a single interaction, pitting them against a perceived unjust authority, and painting himself as the righteous underdog. Long would go on to use this same strategy to campaign across the Bayou State, demonizing the monopolistic Standard oil, and positioning himself as a “young warrior of and for the plain people, battling the evil giants of Wall Street and their corporations,” a strategy that was crucial to beating out his gubernatorial opponents, and one that defines how his supporters characterize him to this day.⁴

More than just positioning himself as a righteous hero fighting against a common foe, Long often lied to those attending his speeches, making up stories about himself, or telling of fictional exploits. For example, while campaigning across Louisiana’s largely Catholic south, Huey would recount the story of how he brought his Catholic grandparents to Mass every Sunday. However, upon his campaign manager remarking that Long had never mentioned his Catholic grandparents, Huey responded curtly, “Don’t be a damned fool... we didn’t even have a horse.”⁵ Huey was adept at tailoring stories depending on who was in the crowd before him, and using this strategy, forged himself as a locally specialized candidate in almost every part of the state. He built an almost parasocial relationship with a large portion of the rural population, constructing a fiercely loyal base that fervently supported him until and after his death. This personal mythos was so powerful that, following Long’s assassination, more than 200,000 people attended his funeral; 17 years after his death, anthropologists met young boys in rural Louisiana who were convinced that Long was president.⁶ While the Kingfish’s cult of personality cemented his support in his home state, this was not the only tool he used to rally the masses.

With the help of his populist rhetoric, Huey Long was able to anger a large swath of the Louisiana population, one which saw placing power in him as the only way to fight against injustice. He first gained this reputation by appealing to the common people through policy proposals. Louisiana at the time of Huey’s rise was in rough shape. Nationally, the Great Depression had hit export-based Louisiana especially hard, compounding the economic woes the state was already feeling as it was squeezed out of the cotton industry by Egypt and India. On top of this, since the Civil War, the state’s political system had

⁴ William Hair, *The Kingfish and His Realm: The Life and Times of Huey P. Long* (LSU Press, 1991), 88.

⁵ White, *Kingfish*, 17.

⁶ Roy Reed, “Huey Long’s Legacy, 40 Years After Death,” *The New York Times*, September 8, 1975, accessed April 28, 2021, <https://www.nytimes.com/1975/09/08/archives/huey-longs-legacy-40-years-after-death.html>.

been dominated by the wealthy planter class, which strangled its development and made local elections essentially meaningless for the average voter. All of this left the populace disillusioned with the status quo and destroyed any loyalty they would have had to the political establishment, leaving the door open for a leader like Long.

As historian T. Williams claims, “Long was the first Southern mass leader to abandon race-baiting and appeals to the gold-misted past and address himself to socio-economic ills.”⁷ While his opponents lamented the evils of northern aggression and reconstruction, taking firm pro or anti-KKK stances, Long did something new: he focused almost exclusively on the economic and social issues that affected his base’s everyday life, practically ignoring issues of race or history. He promised new roads to rural towns, free textbooks for school children, modernization of the state’s hospitals, improvements to local universities, and, perhaps most influentially, the repeal of the poll tax. These stances helped make him immensely popular in his native Winn Parish and gave him the momentum to go statewide in his two gubernatorial runs.

Though his social programs were popular, they are not what led the Kingfish to be characterized as a textbook populist; the blame for this falls instead on his habit of laying the responsibility for his state’s, and later country’s, woes squarely on the shoulders of the large corporations and the ultra-rich. In one of his most famous speeches, the 1934 Every Man a King address, Huey talks of this directly:

Is that a right of life, when the young children of this country are being reared into a sphere which is more owned by 12 men than it is by 120 million people?... It is not the difficulty of the problem which we have; it is the fact that the rich people of this country-and by rich people I mean the super-rich-will not allow us to solve the problems, or rather the one little problem that is afflicting this country, because in order to cure all of our woes it is necessary to scale down the big fortunes, that we may scatter the wealth to be shared by all of the people.⁸

Just as nationalists with foreign powers or religious fundamentalists with infidels, the Kingfish created a powerful “us versus them” mentality among his supporters by shifting the blame for everything from bad roads to late veteran payments onto the rich. He was able to condense his rhetoric down to raging against an amorphous boogeyman in the

⁷ John Adam Moreau, “Huey Long and His Chroniclers,” *Louisiana History: The Journal of the Louisiana Historical Association* 6, no. 2 (Spring 1965): 121-39, <https://www-jstor-org.ezproxy.milton.edu/stable/4230837>.

⁸ Huey Long, “Every Man a King,” Speech, Radio Address, February 23, 1934.

one percent, instead of confronting the actual complex economic and structural issues that plagued the state. On top of this, Long was able to brush off his critics by accusing them of being in the pockets of the wealthy. Using these strategies, Huey was able to mobilize his base in a way not seen in the rest of the south, and rare even in the more urban North, sweeping elections even when he did not have majority support. Furthermore, by insinuating that his opponents were in the pocket of a group set on keeping his supporters poor, Huey destroyed trust in the wider government, instead concentrating confidence in himself alone, making it easier to justify his later dismantling of the said democratic government. While Long managed to rally the support of the Louisiana populace through his populism and cult of personality, he could not always do the same for the state's prolific press, sparking a bitter rivalry.

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Huey Long's rivalry with, bullying of, and disenfranchisement of the press upon his election demonstrates how democratic institutions are not always infallible in the face of political will. One of Long's best-remembered features was his long-standing rivalry with the press, but this bitter rivalry only really began once he took the office of governor. What is less well-remembered is how for "nearly a decade ... [newspapers] had provided him with a platform to explain his ideas and convince potential supporters he was worthy of their vote."⁹ The press treated him much as it did for any young and popular upstart politicians, covering his every move, in both a positive and negative light, exaggerating both the good and bad. Long did show signs of at least annoyance with some of the negative coverage of his, joking during his first gubernatorial campaign that "One day you pick up the papers and see where I killed four priests . . . Another day I murdered twelve nuns, and the next day I poisoned four hundred babies," but in general, he retained a neutral opinion of the papers while they still advanced his goal of an eventual election.¹⁰

However, once he did manage to get elected, Huey did not retain the same mixed press coverage he had as a candidate. Alienated by his authoritarian moves upon taking office, newspapers around the state quickly shifted tones and began lambasting the newly elected governor, earning his ire. This came to a head during Long's impeachment trial, only a year after his election. Every one of the state's 21 independent newspapers took firm anti-Long stances, calling for his removal from office. In response, Long took to his per-

⁹ Christina A Georgacopoulos, "How 'Lyingnewspapers' Made Huey Long the Ruler of His State: A Model of Press-Populist Dynamics," 2021, 2.

¹⁰ Gerald Early, "Touchstone Texts: It Can't Happen Here," *The Common Reader*, April 20, 2021, accessed May 9, 2021, <https://commonreader.wustl.edu/c/touchstone-texts-it-cant-happen-here/>.

sonally distributed circulars to “warn the public they could not trust what they read about him in the ‘lying newspapers.’”¹¹ By telling his devoted fanbase that they could no longer trust the media, Long put the press in the same boat as he had opposing politicians and vocal critics: defenders of the entrenched elite who were scared of Huey’s needed reforms, effectively neutralizing any damage the press could have done to his popularity.

In a less-publicized move to stifle the press, Long introduced a bill that would “allow the state to seek an injunction to stop the publication of any newspaper deemed ‘obscene, lewd, or lascivious,’ or malicious, scandalous, or defamatory.”¹² Because Long had consolidated significant control of the state government by this time, the bill would have effectively allowed Long to dismantle any newspapers that criticized him, a gross violation of the first amendment. Fortunately for the press, and unfortunately for Long, the bill was blocked in committee. However, Huey was not done attempting to suppress criticism of himself. Four years later, after Long and his allies had obtained complete control of the state government, Huey extra-legally engineered legislation designed to punish his opponents in the press, and this time, “the bill passed, creating a state printing board that... gave Long the ability to reward or punish press outlets based on their coverage of him.”¹³ Through this bill, the Kingfish could have achieved the perfect echo chamber for pro-Long sentiment in Louisiana. Although by this time he was more focused on national politics and had to contend with the more entrenched nationwide media, the fact that he not only attempted to but succeeded in dominating dissenting local press shows how effective his political strategy had been, and how easily he had dismantled the institutions meant to stop him.

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The rise of Huey Long stands out among the many authoritarian takeovers of history in that throughout it, Long never lost his popularity. His kidnapping of political enemies, corruption, and takeover of the state senate did not put a dent in the sway he held over the populace, and some even suggest it made him more popular. As he famously stated on the floor of the Louisiana legislature, “I am the constitution ‘round here now,” and by and large, he was right.¹⁴ He managed this using three key tactics, a voracious cult

¹¹ Alecia P. Long, “Huey Long vs. The Media,” *64 Parishes*, Spring/Summer 2018, accessed April 26, 2021, <https://64parishes.org/huey-long-vs-the-media>.

¹² Alecia P. Long, “Huey Long vs. The Media.”

¹³ Alecia P. Long, “Huey Long vs. The Media.”

¹⁴ Jerry P. Sanson, *“What He Did and What He Promised to Do...” : Huey Long and the Horizons of Louisiana Politics* (N.p., 2006), <https://www-jstor-org.ezproxy.milton.edu/stable/4234200>, 265.

of personality, aggressive populist rhetoric, and his bullying and suppressing of the press. His rise acts as a basic roadmap for leaders the world over who wish to consolidate power in themselves, and dismantle the checks on their authority, and the modern world has seen several follow it to a tee. From Orban and Duda from the right to Chavez and Morales from the left, the Long strategy has been shown to be as effective as ever. All of these examples demonstrate how democracy is not an immovable monolith, put in place by great men who were wiser than us. It shifts and changes with the times, and with enough of a push, can be toppled. It is important to scrutinize the rise of Huey Long and avoid the notion that It Can't Happen Here, so that it never does.

SANDRA DAY O'CONNOR

A Voice for Nonpartisanship on the Supreme Court

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Journalists and historians frequently misidentify Justice Sandra Day O'Connor as a justice whose political ideology transformed throughout her legal career. Justice O'Connor, a strong advocate for apolitical jurisprudence, repeatedly fought to dismantle policies that discriminated on the basis of sex, shattering the glass ceiling in every position she occupied and paving the way for future female politicians and lawyers to pursue careers in a male-dominated field. Many argue that, when she was appointed to the Supreme Court in 1981 as the first female justice, she shifted from being a conservative to a moderate or even a liberal influence on the court. Particularly in the areas of women's rights and reproductive rights, she more often sided with the liberals on the court than with her conservative colleagues. However, 1981 also signaled the beginning of a rampant increase in ideological polarization on the Court. O'Connor joined the Burger Court and found herself in the midst of a partisan revolution. While the increasing ideological polarization in the Supreme Court created the appearance of a shift in O'Connor's political ideology from conservative to more moderate, O'Connor's legal decisions remained consistently apolitical. Her commitment to nonpartisanship contributed to the preservation of reproductive rights in the United States.

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Despite pervasive gender discrimination posing numerous obstacles throughout O'Connor's legal career, the justice demolished every discriminatory hurdle in her way. After graduating Stanford Law School, O'Connor struggled to find a job, as few firms were willing to hire female attorneys. O'Connor eventually negotiated an unsalaried job, and

soon worked as a deputy county attorney despite not being compensated for her work.¹ During the first few years of her legal career, O'Connor worked as an attorney for a number of organizations and municipalities. In 1969, she was elected to the Arizona Senate, where she later served as the first female state senate Majority Leader in the United States.² After a historic five years in the Arizona State Senate, O'Connor moved on to work as a Superior Court judge and later on the Arizona Court of Appeals in Phoenix.³ Her perseverance and remarkable legal record captured the attention of Republican President Ronald Reagan. President Reagan nominated O'Connor to the Supreme Court of the United States in 1981 to replace centrist Potter Stewart. In September of that year, the Senate confirmed O'Connor on a unanimous 99-0 vote.⁴ When the Court came into session that fall, all eyes were on the first female justice.

Reagan's nomination stemmed from two fundamental factors: a promise to the American people to nominate a female justice to the Supreme Court and a desire for an objective and ideologically flexible justice.⁵ O'Connor fulfilled both requirements; Reagan, however, faced backlash from the public. Conservatives resented O'Connor's support of legal abortion, as well as her support of the Equal Rights Amendment, and liberals felt that her social advocacy did not go far enough. Despite their concerns, O'Connor's moderate conservatism was a strategically safe choice designed to appeal to most Americans.

Historians and journalists' who characterized O'Connor as shifting away from traditional conservatism and towards centrism neglected to acknowledge the increasing partisan polarization on the Supreme Court. During the beginning of her time on the Court, O'Connor's decisions often aligned with those of the other conservative justices, earning her the descriptor of "a 'classic conservative'" by journalists.⁶ However, as the years went by, and as the political makeup and ideologies of the Court shifted, journalists began to call O'Connor "a moderate... a centrist, a moderate centrist."⁷ Journalist Lyle Denniston, for example, described O'Connor as a "moderate establishment progressive" in a 1999

¹ "Sandra Day O'Connor," *Britannica*, accessed April 24, 2021, <https://www.britannica.com/biography/Sandra-Day-OConnor>.

² "Sandra Day O'Connor."

³ "Sandra Day O'Connor."

⁴ "Sandra Day O'Connor."

⁵ Gil Troy, "Why Ronald Reagan Picked Sandra Day O'Connor--And Why George W. Bush Might Want to Follow His Example," *History News Network*, accessed May 2, 2021, <https://historynewsnetwork.org/article/12821>.

⁶ Abigail Perkiss, "A Look Back at Justice Sandra Day O'Connor's Court Legacy," National Constitution Center, last modified July 1, 2020, accessed April 13, 2021, <https://constitutioncenter.org/blog/a-look-back-at-justice-sandra-day-oconnors-court-legacy>.

⁷ Perkiss, "A Look Back."

Baltimore Sun article.⁸ In the eyes of the journalists, O'Connor's political ideologies had shifted. However, legal analysis indicates that rather than the Justice's political ideology shifting, the political ideologies of the court around her shifted instead.

Rather than O'Connor's political ideology shifting left, the drastic increase in ideological polarization on the Supreme Court created the impression that O'Connor became more liberal. When O'Connor first stepped onto the Court in 1981, liberal justices comprised the majority of the bench.⁹ By the time she left the court in 2006, however, the makeup of the court had shifted right, and conservative voices dominated the court's decisions.¹⁰ In addition to the change in political makeup, the Court also experienced ideological polarization. The spike in polarization stemmed from the increase in consistent justices. Many of the justices were predictable in their voting; they reliably voted along party lines and with the justices that shared their liberal or conservative ideology. The justices that acted as swing votes, however, were rapidly disappearing. These justices formed the political center, and their decisions did not resonate with any overarching ideology. Following in O'Connor's footsteps after her retirement, Justice Anthony Kennedy acted as the Court's swing vote. Appointed as a conservative justice by President Reagan, Kennedy voted with liberals and conservatives alike. Unlike many of his colleagues, and similar to O'Connor, his ideology was difficult to pinpoint.¹¹ The political center that O'Connor and Kennedy engaged with "slowly disappeared, especially since the 1980s" because of the increase in partisan sorting and ideological separation.¹² Partisan sorting meant that "conservatives increasingly [migrated] to the Republican Party and liberals to the Democratic Party," and this happened because the values and priorities of the two parties increasingly became more disparate.¹³ The two groups had trouble finding common ground, and this difficulty translated into an increasingly divided Supreme Court. Presidents would nomi-

⁸ Perkiss, "A Look Back."

⁹ Evan Thomas, "How the Supreme Court Justice Sandra Day O'Connor Helped Preserve Abortion Rights," *The New Yorker*, accessed April 13, 2021, <https://www.newyorker.com/news/news-desk/how-the-supreme-court-justice-sandra-day-oconnor-helped-preserve-abortion-rights>.

¹⁰ Thomas, "How the Supreme Court."

¹¹ Colin Dwyer, "A Brief History Of Anthony Kennedy's Swing Vote — And The Landmark Cases It Swayed," *NPR*, accessed April 22, 2021, <https://www.npr.org/2018/06/27/623943443/a-brief-history-of-anthony-kennedys-swing-vote-and-the-landmark-cases-it-swayed>.

¹² Brandon Bartels, "The Sources and Consequences of Polarization in the U.S. Supreme Court," George Washington University, accessed May 1, 2021, <https://home.gwu.edu/~bartels/Bartels%20Chapter%20-%20Polarization%20Volume%20FINAL.pdf>.

¹³ Neal Devins and Lawrence Baum, "SPLIT DEFINITIVE: HOW PARTY POLARIZATION TURNED THE SUPREME COURT INTO A PARTISAN COURT," The University of Chicago, accessed May 1, 2021, <https://www.journals.uchicago.edu/doi/pdfplus/10.1086/691096>.

nate judicial candidates who they felt were sensitive to their party's agenda and view of the Constitution, consequently contributing to the lack of apolitical justices.

As the political center vanished, the conservative justices moved further right and the liberal justices moved further left, leaving those who did not conform to partisan jurisprudence as swing votes. O'Connor, however, did not shift right with the rest of the conservative justices. Prior to the extreme increase in polarization, O'Connor voted mostly with the conservative justices; however, when the conservatives shifted right, O'Connor began to identify less with their beliefs, and she voted with liberal and centrist justices in addition to the conservative justices.¹⁴ Because of her previous voting record, she stood out as an enigma when compared to her colleagues during the second half of her time on the court. The media identified this apparent "shift" as a change in O'Connor's ideology, when in actuality, the reason she began voting with centrists and liberals was because the court had shifted around her. The makeup of the court became more right leaning and the conservative justices became more vehemently conservative, ultimately contributing to the appearance of a "shift" in O'Connor's political ideology.

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O'Connor's jurisprudence centered around the idea that "[her] obligation [was] to define the liberty of all, not to mandate [her] own moral code."¹⁵ O'Connor stood fiercely against the politicalization of the Court, and she firmly believed that individual morals and ethics had no place in the courtroom. Considering herself to be an apolitical justice, O'Connor allowed the law to be the only contributing factor in her decisions. She believed that "the law [provided] necessary continuity amidst [a] constantly shifting political landscape. It is an assurance that the rules of the game [applied] equally to everybody, whether they [were] in today's or yesterday's majority."¹⁶ O'Connor's philosophy boiled down to one notion: political ideology should not impact a justice's interpretation of the law. Believing that politics and jurisprudence were two separate spheres, O'Connor followed a strict, apolitical understanding of American law. She explained in a New York Times interview that she "tried to decide each case based on the law and the Constitution," instead of personal morals and political beliefs.¹⁷

¹⁴ Perkiss, "A Look Back."

¹⁵ Official Reports of the Supreme Court. United States: Supreme Court, 2007.

¹⁶ Sandra Day O'Connor, "My Exclusive Interview with Justice Sandra Day O'Connor," *The Huffington Post*, last modified 2009, accessed April 5, 2021, https://www.huffpost.com/entry/exclusive-interview-with_b_188581.

¹⁷ Sandra Day O'Connor, "Case Closed," interview, *The New York Times*, last modified 2009, accessed April 13, 2021, <https://www.nytimes.com/2009/03/22/magazine/22wwwln-q4-t.html>.

Because of her refusal to be influenced by partisan polarization and politics, O'Connor frequently cast the swing vote on divided cases. Most of the justices were predictable and voted based on party lines, meaning that all eyes were on O'Connor to see how she would vote. Her beliefs did not resonate with either polarized side of the aisle, making her voting unpredictable. The *Bush v. Gore* case, for example, concerned the constitutionality of the Florida ballot recounts during the 2000 presidential election.¹⁸ The decision fell to the conservative wing of the Court, and O'Connor voted alongside the majority. In the *McConnell v. Federal Election Commission* case, however, O'Connor voted with the liberal wing. The case centered around the Bipartisan Reform Act of 2002, and it questioned not only the relationship between regulations on political advertising and the First Amendment, but also the extent of Congress' power in regulating elections.¹⁹ The *Washington Post* put it best when they described O'Connor as "a conservative but independent justice with no overarching ideology."²⁰ O'Connor firmly and bravely stuck to her own philosophy, and she did not allow herself to be swayed by the partisan division that pervaded U.S. politics. Reflecting on her nonconformity, O'Connor explained that "unpopular judicial decisions [were] especially important because the rule of law [was] worthless if it [was] only followed when it [was] popular. [The judiciary was] most [needed] to uphold the law during times when it [was] least popular to do so."²¹ This belief may explain why even when faced with public backlash and pressure, O'Connor consistently upheld her judicial integrity.

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An examination of a few key cases illustrated that O'Connor's view of the Constitution did not change as radically as journalists hypothesized. Both the public and the media expected O'Connor to vote with the conservative justices; however, O'Connor quickly defied this expectation in the 1982 case *Mississippi University for Women v. Hogan*, which considered the constitutionality of the University's women only admissions policy.²² O'Connor voted with the liberal justices that the women-only policy breached the Equal

¹⁸ "Bush v. Gore, 531 U.S. 98 (2000)," Justia, accessed April 25, 2021, <https://supreme.justia.com/cases/federal/us/531/98/>.

¹⁹ "MCCONNELL, UNITED STATES SENATOR, ET AL. v. FEDERAL ELECTION COMMISSION ET AL.," Supreme Court of the United States, accessed April 27, 2021, <https://www.supremecourt.gov/opinions/03pdf/02-1674.pdf>.

²⁰ Marjorie Williams, "How Sandra Day O'Connor Became the Most Powerful Woman in 1980s America: A 1989 Post Story Traces the Quiet Drive of the First Female Supreme Court Justice.," *The Washington Post*, accessed April 7, 2021, <https://www.washingtonpost.com/news/arts-and-entertainment/wp/2016/03/29/how-sandra-day-oconnor-became-the-most-powerful-woman-in-1980s-america/>.

²¹ O'Connor, "My Exclusive Interview."

²² "Mississippi Univ. for Women v. Hogan, 458 U.S. 718 (1982)," Justia, accessed April 25, 2021, <https://supreme.justia.com/cases/federal/us/458/718/>.

Protection Clause, quickly proving early on in her Supreme Court tenure that she would not sacrifice the law in favor of partisan politics. As the ideological makeup of the court shifted, so did O'Connor's voting. Initially, O'Connor's beliefs resonated with those of the conservative justices, but when the conservatives moved farther right, she "emerged as a justice who looked to resolve each case and no more, one with no overarching philosophy that might preordain a result."²³ The liberal and conservative wings of the court had shifted so much that O'Connor's voting no longer resonated with the values of one specific group. Despite the media's interpretation of O'Connor's political ideology, the increase in polarization indicated that rather than O'Connor's political ideologies shifting, the ideologies of her fellow justices shifted. Justice O'Connor became a swing vote not because her own political ideologies dramatically shifted left, but because the rest of the court shifted further right. When cases became increasingly more partisan, the responsibility often fell upon Justice O'Connor to be the deciding vote on contentious topics.

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O'Connor's status as "swing vote" made her the deciding vote that preserved reproductive rights. O'Connor had always been a strong advocate for women's rights, even before President Reagan nominated her to the Supreme Court. O'Connor explained in a New York Times interview that when she "was in the Arizona Legislature, one of the things that [she] did was to examine every single statute in the state of Arizona to pick out the ones that discriminated against women and get them changed."²⁴ O'Connor's experience with gender discrimination in her career motivated her to fight for equality for all women in the U.S. Later, once she began her tenure on the Supreme Court, O'Connor explained she often felt that "if [she] stumbled badly in doing the job, [she thought] it would have made life more difficult for women, and that was a great concern of [hers]."²⁵ The Justice displayed strong support for women's rights throughout her legal history; her passion for gender equality was unwavering. What made O'Connor such an effective justice was her ability to separate personal beliefs from the law. O'Connor herself was opposed to abortions, but she refused to allow her personal beliefs to trump the Constitution and the law. After the controversial 1973 *Roe v. Wade* decision, which preserved the right to abortions in the U.S., O'Connor was forced to grapple with the legal boundaries of ruling over abortions.²⁶ "When the *Roe* decision came under fire from conservative activists and the Su-

²³ Williams, "How Sandra Day O'Connor."

²⁴ Sandra Day O'Connor, "Case Closed," interview, *The New York Times*, last modified 2009, accessed April 13, 2021, <https://www.nytimes.com/2009/03/22/magazine/22wwln-q4-t.html>.

²⁵ Ann, McFeatters, *Sandra Day O'Connor: Justice in the Balance* (University of New Mexico Press, 2006).

²⁶ "Roe v. Wade, 410 U.S. 113 (1973)," Justia, accessed April 26, 2021, <https://supreme.justia.com/cases/federal/>

preme Court's balance shifted toward the Republican Party, her struggle became the whole country's."²⁷ Because of the partisan divide in the Court, all eyes were on Justice O'Connor, and O'Connor, just as she had done countless times before, diligently ensured that her personal biases did not influence her decision. During the 1992 *Planned Parenthood of Southeastern Pennsylvania v. Casey* case, O'Connor formed a secret alliance with Justice Kennedy and Justice Souter. The three justices held meetings to create "a joint opinion that, when added to the pro-abortion votes of Blackmun and John Stevens, would effectively negate Rehnquist's effort to gut *Roe v. Wade*."²⁸ The case was split down the middle, and O'Connor's vote turned the case into a 5-4 decision that reaffirmed the *Roe v. Wade* decision almost two decades before. O'Connor's status as swing vote allowed her to break a tie in a contentious, divided case. Her vote in the *Planned Parenthood v. Casey* case "secured a fragile national consensus" surrounding abortions in America, laying the foundation for future abortion cases on a state and federal level.²⁹ O'Connor's vote in favor of reproductive rights preserved the right to safe abortions in the U.S.

Sandra Day O'Connor's commitment to nonpartisanship allowed her to be a consistent voice for justice and equality in a volatile, polarized Supreme Court. Justice O'Connor resented the increasing role that politics played in the Court, and she tirelessly strived to preserve the purpose of the Court: nonpartisan jurisprudence with a focus on the law, not politics. She ensured that her personal biases did not influence her decisions. As the Court became more ideologically polarized, and her fellow justices began shifting further left or right, O'Connor found herself as the Court's swing vote. In divided decisions, such as the *Planned Parenthood v. Casey* case, O'Connor often cast the deciding vote. Being the swing vote came with elevated power and influence, and all eyes were on O'Connor. This public scrutiny that came from being a swing vote was the reason that the journalists were so intent on labeling O'Connor as a liberal or conservative. Their hyperfocus on her ideology caused them to miss the shift of the Court because they were so fixated on O'Connor as the visible swing vote. O'Connor faced increasing outside pressures and resistance, but she responded to the pressure with calmness and confidence, never letting herself fall into the partisan trap. O'Connor's resilience and commitment to the law rendered her an exceptional justice. Her ability to challenge the status quo and disturb the partisanship that

[us/410/113/](#).

²⁷ Thomas, "How the Supreme Court."

²⁸ Thomas, "How the Supreme Court."

²⁹ Thomas, "How the Supreme Court."

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overtook the Court contributed to her lasting, historic legacy. Justice O'Connor's diligent, passionate work preserved reproductive rights in the United States and built the foundation for future reproductive rights policy and rulings.

FREDERICK DOUGLASS

Abolitionist Trailblazer

EMMANUEL UZOBUIFE

Milton Academy '22

In the 1800s, Frederick Douglass was born a slave, escaped, and became a prominent figure in the abolitionist movement. Shortly after escaping, he joined the Anti-Slavery Society, an activist group working towards the abolition of slavery. He was notable because he fought not only for abolition, but also for the equal rights of black people. Throughout his life, he played many positions for the abolitionist cause, from writer to speaker, and from Presidential advisor to diplomat to Haiti. Douglass fought against slavery and for equal rights by his challenge to the social narrative of black inferiority. He also combatted slavery unorthodoxly in that, unlike Garrisonian abolitionists, he argued that the Constitution was not a racist document, but rather self-contradictory. Douglass was especially effective in his use of prized American institutions like the Constitution, the Declaration of Independence, and Christianity that racist whites purported to uphold in order to expose the hypocrisy of those racist whites as well as to justify his arguments against slavery.

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Douglass was born around 1817 to a slave woman and, in all likelihood, his slave master, Hugh Auld, in Maryland. When Douglass was twelve years old, Auld's wife, Sophia Auld, taught him to read and write, but Auld forbade further teaching when he found out. Douglass disobeyed and continued teaching himself to read and write despite his father's prohibition, but eventually, Hugh Auld would find out and send Douglass to a slave-breaker, named Edward Covey, for his academic transgressions. As a teenager, Douglass suffered under the brutal beatings of Covey, but after months of beatings, one day, Douglass fought back and won, a watershed moment in his life that inspired him to seek freedom.¹ At

¹ Frederick Douglass, *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass: An American Slave*, ed. Benjamin Quarles (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1960), 104.

age twenty, Douglass fled slavery to New York but eventually settled in Massachusetts. He joined the Anti-Slavery Society at twenty-five, where he met William Lloyd Garrison, an established and prominent member of the abolitionist movement, with whom he would travel across the North, promulgating the abolitionist cause. He released his first autobiography at age twenty-seven, and it sold over 5,000 copies in three months and 30,000 in five years. Douglass eventually went on to found the *North Star*, an abolitionist newspaper. He fought slavery through his autobiographies and newspaper articles, his energetic and impassioned speeches, his civic engagement, and even his work for the federal government as a recruiter of black soldiers for the Union Army. Throughout his life and works, Douglass proved to be an essential part of the abolitionist movement.

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Through his academic disobedience of his slaveholder and his rebellion against Covey, Douglass challenged the narrative of black inferiority and stood testament to the mental and physical equality of black people and white people. Douglass' challenge to the black inferiority narrative demonstrated why he was an influential abolitionist. Because the notion of black people being demented and inferior to whites was so pervasive, it was a surprise to many to see an escaped slave passionately speak about his lived experience. Douglass's fellow Garrisonian abolitionists in the Anti-Slavery Society feared that many Northern whites would not believe that he used to be a slave, so they advised him to sound less educated and speak less eloquently than he did.² Rather than follow their advice, Douglass instead wrote an autobiography, further documenting his heritage and establishing his credibility as an intellectual. Douglass possessed skill not only with the written word, but also with the spoken word. His colleague Garrison, who had devoted his life to the abolition of slavery, wrote that he "never hated slavery so intensely as at that moment" when referring to Douglass's speech about his experiences as a slave, a testament to the power of his impassioned speeches.³ Without his lived experience and his logical way of conveying it, Douglass would not have been able to alert so many people to the horrors of slavery. Charles W. Chestnut, an acquaintance of Douglass, stated that because Douglass went through such tumultuous experiences as a slave, he was able to exhibit that his "genius" is the means by which he changed being black from a source of shame to a means by which he "raised himself and his people."⁴ Douglass used what otherwise would have been

² Jay Thompson, "Toward Douglassian Abolitionism: The Rift Between Frederick Douglass and William Lloyd Garrison" (reading, 2002), 2.

³ Thompson, "Toward Douglassian," 2.

⁴ Benjamin Quarles, "Frederick Douglass: Historical and Contemporary Perspectives," *New Directions* 7, no. 2 (1980), <https://dh.howard.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?referer=https://www.google.com/&httpsredir=1&article=1214&context=>

a disadvantage, former enslavement, as a means to become a bulwark of the abolitionist movement.

He also served as an example for what other enslaved people could be. When Douglass was commissioned to enlist black men to serve in the Union Army, he initially struggled to convince free blacks to serve the nation that had formerly enslaved them. However, with Douglass's continued help, almost 200,000 former slaves ultimately joined the Union Army, making up about 10 percent of the entire army.⁵ Had black men not joined the Union Army in such great numbers, the Union might not have won—even if they had, Douglass feared that black people would not have necessarily done anything to “earn” their freedom. Douglass further intimated in his broadside that if former slaves fought in the Civil War, they would prove that they were “worthy to be freemen” and that America was their country just as much as it was a white man's.⁶ Without his urgent and moving diction and the lived experiences through which he could relate to other slaves, Douglass would not have been an effective recruiter to the extent that he was. Without his moving writing and oratory skills, he would have never been in a position to be able to recruit black men into the Union Army; his public speeches and first autobiography are what helped him first gain prominence, and his prominence is what put him in a position to get the recruitment job. Douglass would have never gained the skills needed to be a great orator or writer had he not been willing to defy the social narrative of black inferiority as a child.

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Through his “What to a Slave is the Fourth of July?” speech, Douglass logically exposed the hypocrisy of the way that whites treated black people, and through this, he demonstrated his effectiveness as an abolitionist and why he influenced the overall movement. In the speech, Douglass communicated how a slave being a man is already conceded in the actions of white people. Douglass highlighted the irony in having seventy-two crimes that if committed by a slave, warranted his death, but only two crimes warranted the death of a white person. Douglass asserted that to punish slaves for a crime means to make the assumption that slaves are capable of higher moral intelligence, an assumption that was not compatible with the notion of black people being docile subhumans. Douglass also pointed out how there are laws that forbid slaves from learning to read and write, but

t=newdirections, 17.

⁵ “With Malice Toward None: The Abraham Lincoln Bicentennial Exhibition: Lincoln and Frederick Douglass,” Library of Congress, <https://www.loc.gov/exhibits/lincoln/lincoln-and-frederick-douglass.html#:~:text=Recruiting%20Colored%20Troops,men%20into%20the%20Union%20forces,1.>

⁶ Frederick Douglass, “Men of Color, To Arms! Now or Never!” (reading, Philadelphia, PA, 1863), 2.

he asked where there are such rules for actual animals, and he ultimately communicated how the manhood of a slave is conceded in actions of racist whites, but not their words. He also spoke about how slaves are capable of doing the same work as white people, such as “ploughing, planting and reaping, using all kinds of mechanical tools,” as exhibited by the work they did as slaves, demonstrating the physical capabilities of a slave.⁷ Furthermore, Douglass went on to say that there is no point in arguing that a man is entitled to liberty and is the owner of his body because the whites “have already declared it.”⁸ Douglas utilized the phrasing of the Declaration of Independence that “all men are created equal” against white people. Douglass logically concluded that black people are humans, and used racist whites’ purported ideals in the Declaration against them and in doing so, demonstrated logical thinking and employed moving oratory skills uncommon to black people, an action that further defied the narrative of black people being inferior to white people. Douglass’ oratory skills and logical thinking were uncommon because black people were not allowed to learn how to read and write, a driving factor in the perpetual reinforcement of the ideas of black inferiority narrative. As a testament to the degree to which he was a good speaker, William G. Allen, a professor of rhetoric and belles lettres at Central College, held that he did not know anyone that could approach Douglass’ oratorical skill.⁹ At the core of racism was a belief that black people were inherently inferior to white people, but with his demeanor, words, and logical thinking, Douglass’ demonstrated that the notion did not conform with reality. Through his clear and sound oration of the logic behind the abolitionist cause, Douglass not only promulgated the idea that black people were human beings capable of the same intellectual and physical skill as a white person and therefore worthy of freedom, but he also exemplified the notion in his being, which ultimately added to his notability and furthered his influence in the abolitionist cause.

In regards to the Constitution, Douglass fought slavery in an unorthodox way because he diverged from the Garrisonian view that the Constitution is racist. Douglass took a risk in disagreeing with William Lloyd Garrison and in doing so, used whites’ racist Constitutional arguments against them and exposed that there was no guarantee of slavery in the spirit of the Constitution and was therefore unconstitutional. As Douglass diverged from the Garrisonian status quo, he not only exemplified his uniqueness and confidence as an influential abolitionist, but also demonstrated that black people were capable of think-

⁷ Frederick Douglass, “What to a Slave is the Fourth of July?” (speech, Rochester, NY, July 4, 1852), 17.

⁸ Douglass, “What to a Slave,” 18.

⁹ Quarles, “Frederick Douglass,” 17.

ing for themselves. Originally, Douglass, as a new abolitionist, trusted Garrison's ideas about the Constitution because the Garrisonian abolitionists' were more knowledgeable about the subject than he was and because he had no way of challenging their ideas due to his lack of formal education.¹⁰ The dynamic of Douglass, as a black man, lacking knowledge while Garrison, a white man, was in a position to have more knowledge is reminiscent of the dynamic between slave and slaveholder, but Douglass would break free from his intellectual bondage as well. Douglass broke free from the ignorance by reading and thinking for himself, and coming up with a different conclusion than the rest of the Garrisonians. Instead of thinking that he might be wrong, he ardently defended that the Constitution was not inherently racist because he grew tired of "arguing on the slaveholder's side."¹¹ In being defiant and going against the status quo, Douglass exhibited the qualities of an influential abolitionist because his actions showed that he was capable of thinking for himself. According to historian Herbert Apthekjer, Douglass was the "preeminent philosopher and organizer of the Abolitionist movement."¹² Apthejeker's praise is a testament to the benefit of Douglass' uniqueness in the abolitionist cause. Douglass noticed that the aim of the Constitution was to "to form a more perfect union, establish justice, insure domestic tranquillity... promote the general welfare, and secure the blessing of liberty" so he concluded that there was no way that it could be used to justify a system of "rapine and murder."¹³ He concluded that the Consitution and the institution of slavery were logically incompatible with each other, and that if the Consitution is the supreme law of the land, then the institution of slavery was an affront to it. Douglass' willingness to diverge from the popular narrative and fight for what he believed in is a character mark of his whole demeanor. The popular narrative was that the Constitution was inherently racist because it allowed for slavery, but Douglass persisted in the argument that because its aim is to "secure liberty" and ensure "domestic tranquility," then the Constitution was actually an anti-slavery document. Similarly, the popular narrative was that blacks were docile subhumans that were inferior to whites intellectually and morally, but persisted against this notion as well. Douglass' entire being was a challenge to the status quo, which is why he was a unique and influential figure in the abolitionist movement.

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¹⁰ Frederick Douglass, *My Bondage and My Freedom* (1855), <https://courses.lumenlearning.com/introliterature/chapter/my-bondage-and-my-freedom-by-frederick-douglass/>, 238.

¹¹ "Frederick Douglass's Irish Liberty," last modified February 25, 2011, <http://claver.gprep.org/sjochs/frederick%20Douglass%20and%20Ireland.htm>, 4.

¹² Quarles, "Frederick Douglass," 17.

¹³ Douglass, *My Bondage*, 238.

Douglass, exhibiting a deep adherence to the Christian faith, used Christianity as a justification for the abolition of slavery, equal rights of black people, and the assimilation of black people by exposing the hypocrisy of the slaveholding whites who purported to be Christians. Douglass' exposition of the hypocrisy of white slaveholding "Christians" demonstrated that he had a better understanding of the Christian faith, an affront to the social construct of black people being injudicious and subhuman. Douglass attempted to appeal to the piety of America and leverage their reverence of the Christian faith to further abolitionist causes. He argued that the notion of blacks being subhuman was against the Bible, and in theory, if whites truly cared about their purported Christianity, they would do their best to adhere to all its precepts. Douglass' arguments against slavery using Christian doctrine were likely especially provoking because it challenged the very fabric of the nation, the foundation on which it stood. In the appendix of his first autobiography, Douglass lambasts the "corrupt, slaveholding women-whipping, cradle-plundering, partial and hypocritical Christianity."¹⁴ From personal experience, Douglass knew that the most consistent churchgoers were the cruelest to their slaves, so in addition to his critical writings, he would routinely repeat in his speeches across the North that, "Between the Christianity of this land, and the Christianity of Christ, I recognize the widest possible difference," a scathing remark to those white slaveholders who were under the assumption that they were practicing a good and true Christianity.¹⁵ Douglass even supported racial amalgamation using Christian doctrine. He received a lot of pushback from members of his race when he decided to marry Miss Pitts, a white woman from New York, but Douglass was described as being kind to all members of mankind, regardless of their race or religion, a core virtue of Christian faith.¹⁶ With racial amalgamation, Douglass advocated for the universal human fellowship within Christ that Christ Himself advocated, in the fight for the abolition of slavery, Douglass strived for "one glorious homogeneous people" in America, who recognized the dignity of man.¹⁷ Although Douglass' dream of amalgamation was completely foreign to people who did not even affirm the humanity of slaves let alone demonstrate a desire to treat them as equal, his persistence in equal rights

¹⁴ D. H. Dilbeck, "The Radical Christian Faith of Frederick Douglass," *ChristianityToday*, <https://www.christianitytoday.com/ct/2018/january-february/frederick-douglass-at-200-remembering-his-radical-christian.html>, 6.

¹⁵ Dilbeck, "The Radical Christian," 6.

¹⁶ "Frederick Douglass's Original New York Times Obituary From 1895," *New York Times*, February 14, 2019, <https://www.nytimes.com/2019/02/14/obituaries/frederick-douglass-dead-1895.html>, 4.

¹⁷ Frederick Douglass, "Your Deliverance Draws Nigh!": Frederick Douglass: Emancipation Proclaimed," *Douglass' Monthly*, October 1862, 562.

as the ends of the abolitionist movement exhibited why Douglass was so influential in it. Douglass was more than an abolitionist, but a complete racist equality advocate. Unlike the Garrisonians who advocated for a slow progression towards abolition so as to allow people to adjust to the new conditions, Douglass envisioned a way of American life that recognized the fullness of its principles of liberty and justice for all the people living there, including slaves. As for his observance of the faith, Douglass exemplified the Christian virtue of forgiveness when he wrote to his former slave owner about how he loved him, but hated slavery. In the “I love you, but hate slavery” letter, Douglass detailed how he felt “nothing but kindness” for his former master and that he ran away from slavery and not him.¹⁸ Douglass forgave Hugh Auld, a man who sent Douglass to be viciously beaten by Edward Covey for months because he was educating himself, further exemplifying his Christian virtue of love of mankind, a love of mankind that fueled his eagerness for the end of slavery. The man who officiated Douglass’ wedding to his second wife, Francis J. Grimke, a Presbyterian minister, held that Douglass was morally “lofty in sentiment” and “pure in thought,” another testament to his moral Christian virtue.¹⁹ Furthermore, among the Christian religious, clergyman-educator William J. Simmons, regarded Douglass as the “epitome of the efforts of a noble soul to be what God intended, despite the laws, customs, and prejudices.”²⁰ The contrast between Douglass’ Christian nature of forgiving and moral virtuousness contrasted with the racist whites’ actions towards their slaves contradicted the popular notion of black people being beast-like subhumans, and Douglass’ demeanor itself exposed the hypocrisy.

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Although it seems as if Douglass’ words and actions made him a bulwark of the abolitionist movement, a true testament to that notion would be what people thought of him. Through Douglass’ work, he gained the notoriety of abolitionists, both white and black, and many high-ranking government officials, furthering his influence in the abolitionist and equal rights cause. Many white abolitionists such as N.P. Rogers and Law Olmsted approved of Douglass’ work and accomplishments. N.P. Rogers, an editor of an antislavery weekly newspaper, called Douglass an “extraordinary man”, and Law Olmsted, an abolitionist who traveled to slave states to fight slavery, wrote that Douglass, as an escaped slave, has done more in ten years than the South has done in fifty years “to elevate and dignify the

¹⁸ Frederick Douglass, “I Love You but Hate Slavery” (reading, Rochester, NY, October 4, 1857), 3.

¹⁹ Quarles, “Frederick Douglass,” 16.

²⁰ Quarles, “Frederick Douglass,” 16.

African race.”²¹ Douglass’ recognition amongst white abolitionists spoke to the influence he had within the abolitionist movement and the effectiveness of his abolitionist style in reaching people. The acclaim that Douglass gained increased his notoriety and the possible reach of his ideas, subsequently increasing his influence in the frontlines of the abolitionist movement. Not only did people within the abolitionist movement compliment his accomplishments, but people outside of it as well. At an unveiling of a statue dedicated to Douglass in New York, Governor Theodore Roosevelt denotes that Douglass was a “worthy representative of the American nation.”²² To further achieve equal rights, further combat the black inferiority narrative and show that blacks are just as capable as whites, Douglass was appointed by multiple Republican presidents to government jobs. He served as an advisor to Abraham Lincoln, gaining his acclaim as “the most meritorious man of the nineteenth century.”²³ Rutherford B. Hayes appointed Douglass as U.S. Marshal of the District of Columbia; James Garfield appointed him as the District of Columbia Recorder of Deeds. Benjamin Harrison appointed Douglass as U.S. minister to Haiti, and Ulysses S. Grant appointed him as Secretary of Commission to Santo Domingo. Although black people would not be able to hold many government positions until many years later, Douglass’ career in government served as a further advocacy of equal rights for blacks and a reminder of the inconsistent logic of the notion of black inferiority. Another testament to his influentialness would be to how the South treated him. As historian Benjamin Quarles denotes, even after Douglass’ autobiography made him an increasingly notable and remarkable public figure, racist white Southerners had to “ignore such Blacks as Douglass” because if they did not, Douglass would have caused dissonance with their preconceived notion of black people being “docile... and improvident”, two things Douglass was evidently far from being.²⁴ The South, being intransigent in their racist ways, would be forced to recognize his writing and speaking skills that were an affront to their whole worldview. Douglass’ appearance in multiple newspapers and popular media of the time increased his influence in the abolitionist movement because he was able to promulgate his abolitionist ideas far easier. Douglass gained this influence by his uniqueness, a uniqueness that came from defying the black inferiority narrative.

In the 19th century, Frederick Douglass fought for the abolitionist movement

²¹ Quarles, “Frederick Douglass,” 15.

²² Quarles, “Frederick Douglass,” 15.

²³ “Frederick Douglass National Historic Site,” [nps.gov, https://www.nps.gov/museum/exhibits/douglass/visionary.html](https://www.nps.gov/museum/exhibits/douglass/visionary.html), 1.

²⁴ Quarles, “Frederick Douglass,” 15.

through his insightful writings about his lived experiences as a slave, his passionate speeches, his willingness to diverge from the popular narrative, and his demeanor as a result of his Christian ethic. At the core of everything Douglass did was a drive to fight the social narrative of black inferiority. The significance of Douglass fighting the racist narrative was that it struck to the very core of racism. At the heart of racism is a belief that black people are inherently and incontrovertibly inferior to white people, and Douglass knowing how to read, write, and speak was an insult to the very root of that racism. Douglass emancipating himself mentally through self-education and then physically through his escape from slavery and dedicating his life to its abolition was an attack at the foundation of slavery and a factor in its ultimate downfall. Had Douglass never defied and fought against the black inferiority narrative as a slave, he would never have gone on to influence the number of people he did as a free man, including the Republican presidents who were pivotal in the fight for abolition and later equal rights. Douglass's actions represented the very means by which slavery was extirpated from American life: abolitionists' unwavering refusal to submit to an unjust status quo.

